



A LOCAL-LIVING GUIDE

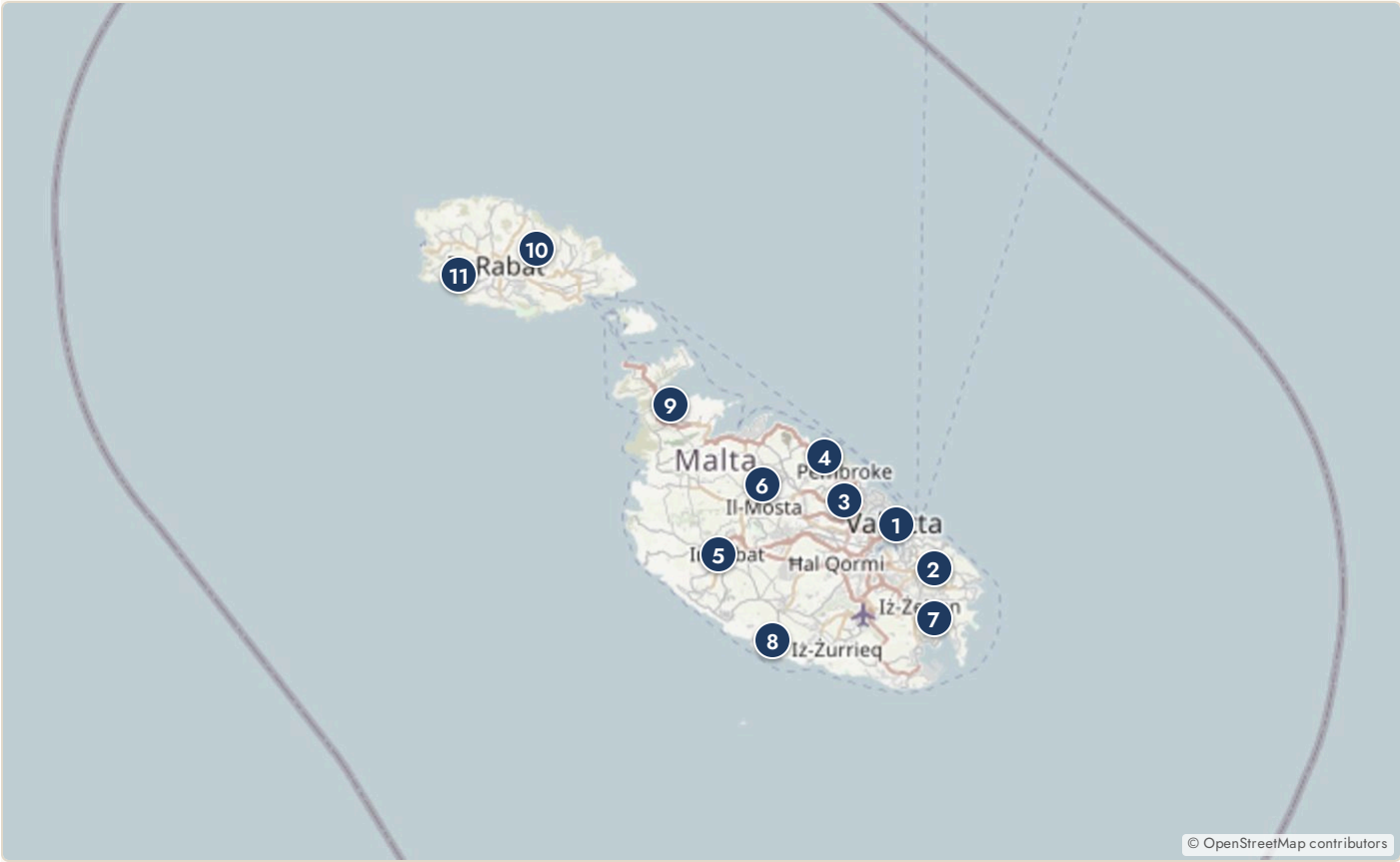
Malta & Gozo, *area* by area

Harbour towns, temples older than the pyramids, village festas, rock-ledge swims and rabbit suppers — a month of living on the islands, not just visiting them.

ANDREW & SYLVAIN · EDITION OF SEPTEMBER 2026

The areas

Malta is small — about 27 km end to end — with Gozo a 25-minute ferry to the north-west. Valletta and the harbour towns are the hub; everything else is a bus ride or a boat away. Each chapter opens with its own map, and every numbered bubble matches an entry in the listings.



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Seasons, closures & passes

When to go

Late September–October and April–May are the sweet spots. September: air about 26°C, sea 25°C. October: 22°C, the sea cooling from 23°C to about 20°C.

November: 18°C with 8–10 rain days. The north-east *gregale* blows more from November and can cancel fast ferries and Blue Grotto boats.

Closures

Heritage Malta sites close 1 Jan, Good Friday and 24, 25 and 31 Dec, with last entry 30 minutes before closing; winter hours start 1 November. St John's Co-Cathedral and Mdina Cathedral close on Sundays. Many shops close Sunday and at midday in the villages. Public holidays this season: 8, 13 and 25 Dec.

Heritage Malta Multisite Pass

About €50 (reduced €30 at 60+), valid 30 days — made for a month's stay. Covers about 25 sites: the temples, Grand Master's Palace, Fort St Elmo, the Archaeology Museum, the catacombs, the Gozo Ċittadella. It does **not** cover the Hypogeum or St John's.

Book the Hypogeum now

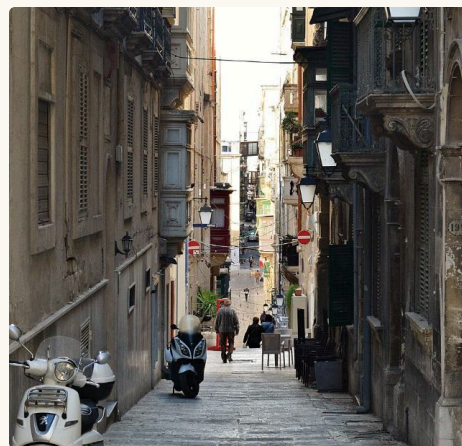
Hal Saflieni takes 10 people per slot. Tickets (€35, 60+ €20) open about 3 months ahead and sell out weeks in advance. Last-minute €50 tickets go on sale the day before at Fort St Elmo and a few other sites — queues form before 7:30.

Money, language, plugs

Euro; contactless almost everywhere, including buses, but carry coins for pastizzi shops. Tip 5–10% at sit-down meals. English is an official language. UK three-pin plugs (Type G). Tap water is safe, though most locals prefer bottled for the taste.

Entry for Canadians

No visa: Malta is Schengen (90 days in 180 across the zone). The EU's biometric Entry/Exit System has been live since April 2026 — expect fingerprints and a photo on arrival. ETIAS is not needed in 2026; the EU now points to 2027 (€20, free over 70).



A Valletta side street, with its wooden *gallariji* — Enrique Íñiguez Rodríguez (Qoan) Credit informat · CC BY-SA 4.0

This autumn: Notte Bianca in Valletta on 3 Oct · In Guardia parade at Fort St Elmo on Sundays 18 & 25 Oct, 1 & 15 Nov, 6 & 13 Dec · Rolex Middle Sea Race starts 17 Oct · Harbour ferries switch to winter hours on 1 Nov.

Buses, ferries & the Gozo crossing

Buses

Tap a card or pay cash on board; a ticket lasts 2 hours with transfers. €2.50 in summer (to 18 Oct), €2 in winter; night routes €3. Best buy for two: the **12-journey card** (€19, shareable, valid 6 months). The Explore 7-day card is €25 each. Use the tallinja app for live times.

Harbour ferries

Sliema ↔ Valletta and Valletta ↔ Three Cities: €3 single, €5 day return (€3.50/€5.20 after 19:30). Summer timetable to 31 Oct (last boat from Sliema 01:00); from 1 Nov boats stop around 19:15. Often faster than the bus.

Taxis & driving

Bolt has the widest coverage, eCabs works 24/7 on both islands, Uber mainly around Valletta and St Julian's. Driving is on the left, traffic is heavy and parking in Valletta nearly impossible; rent a car only for Gozo days.

From the airport

Airport Direct buses (€3; TD1 €3.50): TD4 to Valletta, TD3 to Sliema and St Julian's, TD1 north to Ċirkewwa. Bolt to Valletta is about €12–16; the white-taxi desk charges fixed fares of about €22–25.

Gozo

Gozo Channel car ferry from Ċirkewwa, 25 min, day and night; the foot-passenger return (€4.65) is paid on the way back, at Mgarr. Gozo Highspeed runs Valletta → Mgarr in 45 min (€7.50) and, new in 2026, from Sliema and Bugibba (€8.50/€6.50).

Walking

Valletta's cross-streets drop to the harbours in long flights of steps; the Upper Barrakka lift saves the climb. The Sliema–St Julian's seafront is flat. Walk early or after 17:00 until October and carry water.



Valletta bus terminus, by City Gate — Continentaleurope · CC BY-SA 4.0

LGBTQ+ Malta

The climate

Marriage equality since 2017 (passed 66–1), civil unions since 2014, the EU's first ban on conversion therapy (2016) and a model gender-identity law. Malta was No. 1 on ILGA-Europe's Rainbow Map for a decade and is No. 2 in 2026. Support for same-sex marriage reached 74% in 2023; holding hands in Valletta, Sliema or St Julian's draws no looks. Villages and Gozo are more Catholic and traditional — polite rather than hostile.

Pride

Malta Pride runs in the first half of September (2026: 4–13 Sept, march on the 12th, with Gozo Pride on the 5th). Valletta hosted EuroPride in 2023. The 2027 dates aren't announced yet — worth planning around if your month is September.

A queer-history walk

Q Travel Malta's small-group tours: the Valletta Queer History Walk (2 h, €55) and “Gays vs. the Inquisitor” in Birgu (€59), built around the sodomy trials heard at the Inquisitor's Palace.

No gay village

The scene is small and spread out: Valletta's stepped St John Street (Café Society, with Da Gino opposite), Strait Street's Yard 32, and Maori on the rocks at St Elmo Bay; late nights at Michelangelo in Paceville. Much of the fun is travelling party nights — NERVE, Lollipop, S2S — so check gaymalta.com.

Community

ARC (Allied Rainbow Communities, 181 Melita St, Valletta) organises Pride and runs gaymalta.com's listings; MGRM is the rights movement; Drachma is the LGBTIQ+ Catholic group; LGBTI+ Gozo keeps a map of friendly places. There's no queer bookshop or walk-in centre.

Relaxed favourites

Brunch at gay-owned Elephant Shoe by the Upper Barrakka; evening drinks on the steps at Café Society (jazz nights); sunset at Maori; the monthly Sunday Brunch Bunch drag brunch at Two Buoys in St Julian's.

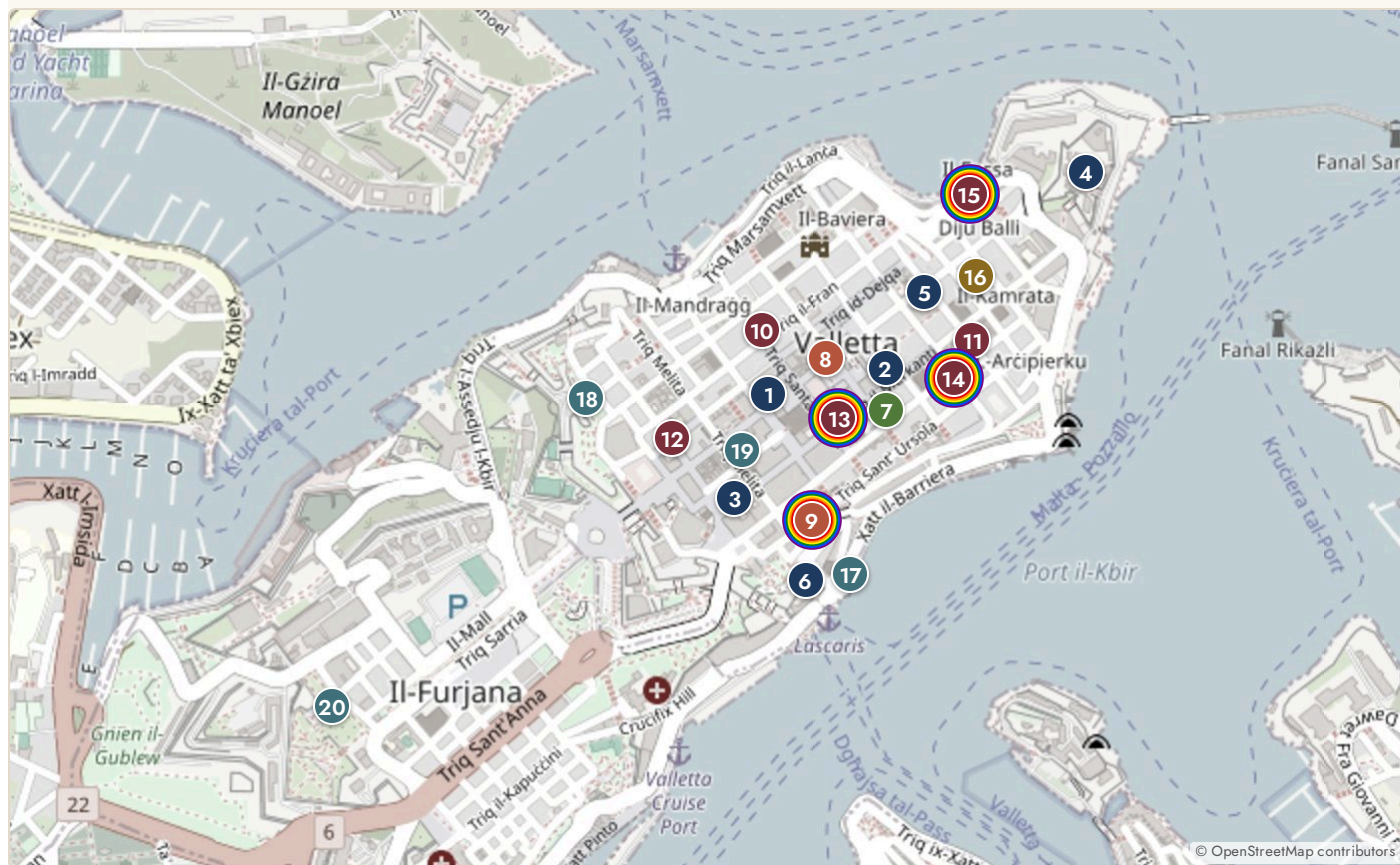


Pride in Valletta — Michasultana · CC BY-SA 4.0

Throughout this guide, the  badge and rainbow-ringed map pins mark gay and LGBTQ+-friendly places. Closed, despite old listings: Monaliza, Chandelier, Birdcage, Just Men sauna.

I Valletta & Floriana

A 1 km grid of honey-coloured limestone with the sea at the end of nearly every street. Cruise passengers fill it from about 10:00 to 16:00; in the evening it turns quiet, local and candle-lit. It is also the heart of Malta's small gay scene — St John Street and St Elmo Bay. Floriana, outside City Gate, is greener and calmer, and home to the main bus terminus.



SIGHTS & MUSEUMS

- 1 St John's Co-Cathedral** — The Knights' gilded Baroque church, floored with some 400 marble tombstones; Caravaggio's *Beheading of St John*, the only painting he signed, is in the Oratory. Mon–Sat 9:00–16:45, closed Sun and holidays; €15 (60+ €12) with audio guide. No stiletto heels; the museum wing is closed for extension.
- 2 Grand Master's Palace** — The Knights' seat of government, still the President's office: frescoed corridors, state rooms, the Armoury. €12 (60+ €10), Multisite Pass. The Throne Room is closed for now.

- 3 MUŻA – National Museum of Art** — Malta's art collection in the Italian Knights' auberge, hung by theme. Daily 10:00–18:00 to October, 9:00–17:00 in Nov–Dec; €10 (60+ €7.50). Courtyard restaurant.
- 4 Fort St Elmo & National War Museum** — The star fort of the 1565 Great Siege, with the George Cross awarded to Malta in 1942 and *Faith*, the surviving Gladiator biplane. **In Guardia** costumed parade at 11:00 on Sundays 18 & 25 Oct, 1 & 15 Nov, 6 & 13 Dec (€17 with the museum).

5 Casa Rocca Piccola — A 16th-century palazzo where the de Piro family still live — sometimes the Marquis guides you himself. 45–60 min tours Mon–Sat from 10:00 (about €15), including a rock-cut WWII shelter and the roof.

6 Lascaris War Rooms — Tunnels under the Upper Barrakka from which the 1943 invasion of Sicily was run. Mon–Sat 9:30–17:30, €20 (cheaper online; card only).



This photo was taken by Anton Zelenov. Please cr · CC BY-SA 4.0

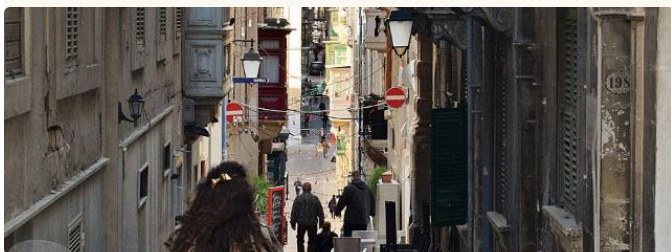
MARKETS & FOOD SHOPS

7 Is-Suq tal-Belt — The restored Victorian market hall: a food market and supermarket downstairs (daily 7:00–21:00), a food court of about 15 kitchens on the ground floor (11:00–22:00).

CAFÉS & SWEETS

8 Caffè Cordina — Valletta's grand café since 1944 (founded 1837 in Bormla). Stand at the bar for coffee and a *qassata*, or sit out facing the old library. Mon–Sat 7:30–21:00, Sun to 15:00.

9 Elephant Shoe  — Brunch café run by a gay couple, in Dar l-Emigrant beside the Upper Barrakka. Mon–Fri 8:00–16:00, weekends 9:00–16:00.



Enrique Íñiguez Rodríguez (Qoan) Credit informat · CC BY-SA 4.0

RESTAURANTS & BARS

10 Leggin — Brick-walled wine bar in the Michelin Guide serving a parade of Maltese dishes with mostly Maltese wines; pre-order the *aljotta* fish soup. Book: 2122 1699.

11 Ta' Nenu — Restaurant in an old bakery: order the Ta' Nenu *ftira* (capers, olives, sausage, cheese), rabbit in white wine and *imqaret* with ice cream. Daily lunch and dinner.

12 Trabuxu — Wine bar in a 400-year-old cellar: farmhouse cheeses, charcuterie, a serious list. Tue–Sat 19:00–midnight; book at weekends.

13 Café Society  — Malta's only full-time gay bar — “the wrong place for the right people”. A small, low-lit room with tables on the steps, jazz and acoustic nights. Mon–Sat 12:00–1:00, Sun from 18:00. Da Gino, opposite, is the overflow for cocktails.

14 Yard 32  — Gay-friendly gin and tapas bar — 200-plus gins, peacock décor, tables on Strait Street, some live music. Wed–Sun 18:30–1:00.

15 Maori  — Lesbian-owned, well-hidden bar on the rocks at St Elmo Bay — murals, hammocks, sunsets over open sea, monthly LipGloss queer nights. Walk down Old Bakery Street and through the tunnel. Wed–Sun from about 17:00.

SHOPPING

16 The Silversmith's Shop — Father-and-son workshop at 219 Republic St making Maltese silver filigree; fair prices, and you can watch them work. Mon–Fri 10:00–17:00, Sat to 15:00, Sun to 13:00.

WALKS, SWIMS & HIDDEN CORNERS

17 Upper Barrakka Gardens & Saluting Battery — The best view of the Grand Harbour and the Three Cities; free, 7:00–22:00. The guns below fire at 12:00 and 16:00 — come 15 minutes early. The lift drops 58 m to the Three Cities ferry.

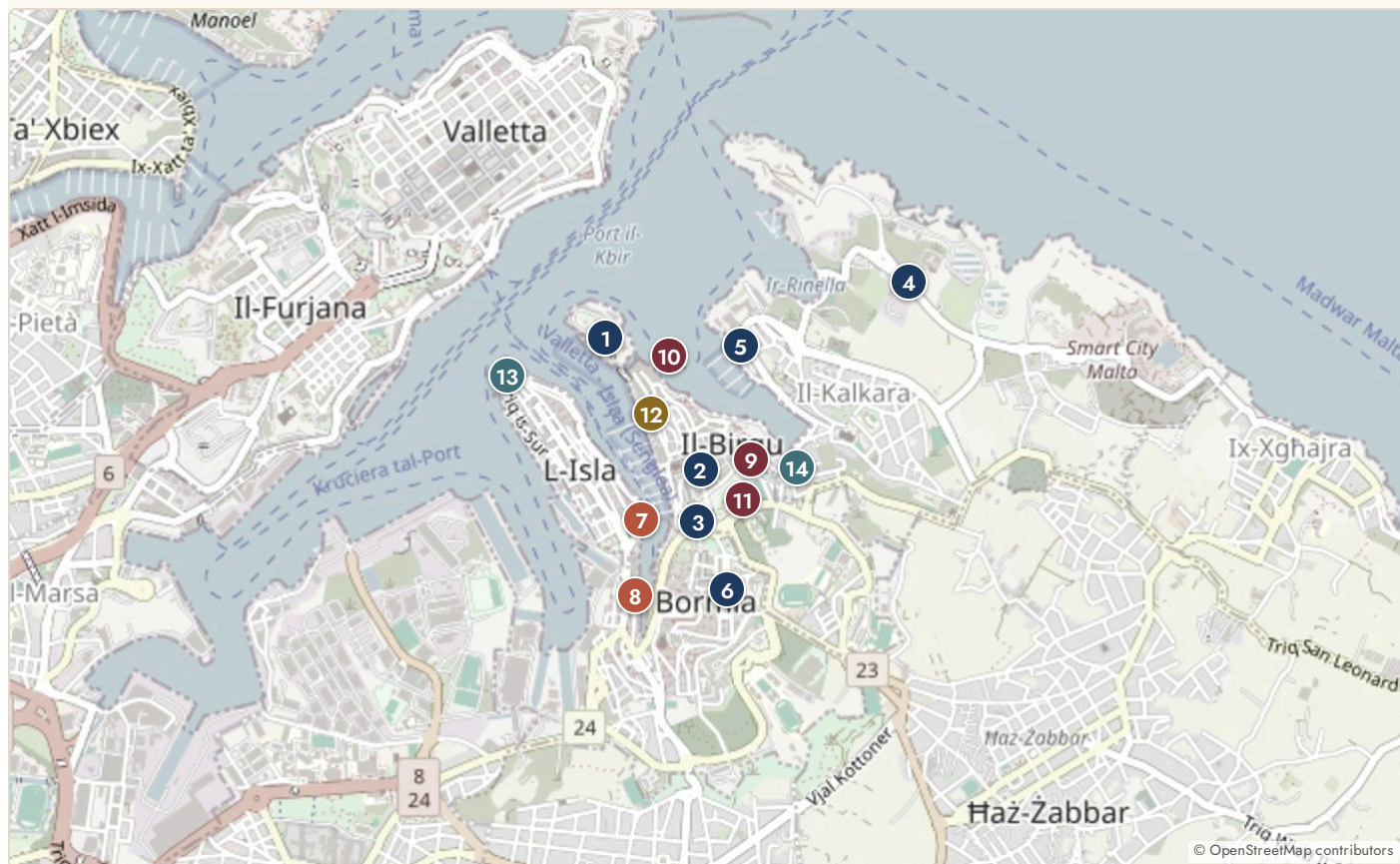
18 Hastings Gardens — The locals' Barrakka: bastion-top lawns by City Gate with sunset views over Marsamxett to Sliema, and hardly anyone else.

19 Strait Street (Triq id-Dejqa) — “The Gut”, the old sailors' music-hall strip, now a narrow lane of wine and cocktail bars in old cellars. Photos in late afternoon, back after 19:00 when the tables come out.

20 Argotti Botanic Gardens — The university's garden on the Floriana bastions — Mediterranean plants, greenhouses, shade — on the walk between City Gate and the bus terminus.

2 The Three Cities & Kalkara

Birgu, Senglea and Bormla (together, “Cottonera”) are older than Valletta and still lived-in: washing on coloured balconies, band clubs on the squares, locals at the waterfront tables. Come back often by the 10-minute ferry or a hand-rowed *dghajsa*; a sunset drink on the Senglea bastions is worth as much as the forts.



SIGHTS & MUSEUMS

- 1 Fort St Angelo** — The Knights' HQ in the Great Siege, Caravaggio's prison in 1608, a Royal Navy base until 1979. Allow 2 hours; little shade, many steps, great harbour views. €10 (60+ €6), Multisite Pass.
- 2 Inquisitor's Palace** — Seat of the Roman Inquisition from 1574: the Inquisitor's rooms, the tribunal, prison cells with prisoners' graffiti. €6 (60+ €4.50). Opens only some days — check Heritage Malta.
- 3 Malta at War Museum** — WWII Malta in the Couvre Porte gate, ending with a walk through a huge rock-cut civilian shelter. Mon–Sat 9:30–17:30, €14 (seniors €12), card only.
- 4 Fort Rinella** — A Victorian battery built round one of two surviving 100-ton Armstrong guns, with costumed guides. Mon–Sat 9:30–17:30, €12. Bus 3 from Valletta; Rinella Bay below for a swim.
- 5 Esplora (Villa Bighi)** — Hands-on science centre and planetarium in the old Royal Naval Hospital. Aimed at families, but the terraces and harbour views justify the climb. €12.

- 6 **Bir Mula Heritage** — A private house-museum restored over 20 years by its owner, with an Arab-period rural structure and ship graffiti. By appointment only: text +356 9927 3276.

MARKETS & FOOD SHOPS

- **Birgu market** — Tuesday mornings: a 750 m street market of produce, fish and housewares under the Cottonera Lines (done by 11:30). Sundays about 6:00–12:00: a sprawling flea market.

CAFÉS & SWEETS

- 7 **The Little Bastion** — The Cugó Gran Macina hotel's terrace in a 16th-century bastion, facing Birgu. Breakfast for non-guests daily 7:30–10:30; dinner Wed–Sun (grilled octopus, *bragioli*).
- 8 **DATE Art Café** — Specialty coffee and art by the water at Bormla's Dock No. 1, looking across to Senglea; live music some evenings.

RESTAURANTS & BARS

- 9 **Tal-Petut** — A tiny room where chef-owner Donald Caligari Conti cooks Maltese food from what he found at market. Dinner Mon–Sat; always book (2189 1169).
- 10 **Terrone** — Michelin-listed seafood in a vaulted room in the bastion walls under Fort St Angelo; wood-fired sole is the signature. Dinner daily, lunch Fri–Mon. 2704 2656.
- 11 **Del Borgo** — Long-running back-street wine bar; good list, platters, rabbit-liver pasta. A quiet evening for two.

SHOPPING

- 12 **Birgu Candlelight Company** — Hand-poured candles and diffusers under the steps of St Lawrence Church, plus candle-making workshops — a packable gift in the town of candlelit BirguFest.

WALKS, SWIMS & HIDDEN CORNERS

- 13 **Gardjola Gardens** — A free little garden at the tip of Senglea. The 1550s sentry box, carved with an eye, an ear and cranes for vigilance, frames the postcard view of Valletta. Best in late light.
- 14 **The Collachio & St Lawrence Church** — Behind Birgu's square, a maze of silent lanes where the Knights lived before Valletta existed. Wander without a plan and finish at St Lawrence on the waterfront.

- **Crossing the harbour** — Valletta–Cospicua ferry about every 30 min (€3 single, €5 return, the return includes the Barrakka lift). Or a hand-rowed *dghajsa* from Lascaris Wharf to Birgu: about €2–3 each, cash, agree the price first.



3 Sliema, Gżira & Ta' Xbiex

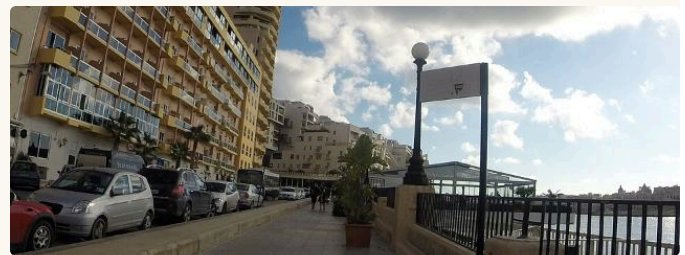
Malta's densest town: a month here means the €3 ferry to Valletta, swims off rock ledges on Tower Road and evening walks along the front to St Julian's. Expect cranes, dust and heavy traffic on the Strand. Gżira is cheaper and more mixed than smart Tigné; there's a queer-run café-bar on Amery Street.



● Sights & Museums ● Cafés & Sweets ● Restaurants & Bars ● Markets & Food Shops ● Shopping ● Walks, Swims & Hidden Corners
 ● LGBTQ+-friendly

SIGHTS & MUSEUMS

- 1 **Stella Maris Church** — Sliema's mother church (1855), built when it was a fishing village. The Paris-made statue of Our Lady is carried through the streets on the third Sunday of August.
- 2 **Fort Tigné** — The Knights' last major fort (1793–95) and one of the first polygonal forts anywhere; fell to the French in 1798. View it from the Tigné Point gardens. Back in public hands since May 2026.
- 3 **Manoel Island & Fort Manoel** — The 1720s fort and the Knights' quarantine hospital, across a small bridge from Gżira. Returned to the state in May 2026 to become a national park; access may be irregular during the handover.



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MARKETS & FOOD SHOPS

- 4 **Jeff's Pastizzeria** — Back-street Gżira pastizzeria, daily 7:00–21:30. Ricotta *pastizzi* and the spinach-and-anchovy pie; most things under €2.

CAFÉS & SWEETS

- 5 **Kaktüs Cafe & Booze**  — Queer-run café by day, cocktail bar by night at 48 Amery St: Turkish coffee, vegan plates, games night on Wednesdays, pre-drinks before queer parties. Open late Fri–Sat.
- 6 **COFFEE & strangers** — Award-winning specialty coffee at 267 Manwel Dimech St. No laptops. Daily 8:00–15:00, Sat to 17:00.
- 7 **Busy Bee** — Family confectioner since 1933 on the Msida/Ta' Xbiex seafront, with its own gelateria. Ricotta *kannoli* and almond sweets; daily 8:00–22:00.



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RESTAURANTS & BARS

- 8 **AYU** — Michelin Bib Gourmand at 209 The Strand: three brothers cooking dishes from around the world, unfused — Sri Lankan black pork curry, Afghan pulao. Informal and good value.
- 9 **Ta' Kris** — Maltese home cooking — slow-cooked classics, octopus, daily fish — now at 154 The Strand. Book 48 hours ahead (2133 7367).
- 10 **The Seafood Market Grill** — Pick your fish at the counter, then have it grilled or fried; ceviche and oysters too. Michelin-listed, mostly local crowd. Phone ahead: 2142 0460.
- 11 **Fernandó Gastrotheque** — Malta's first Michelin star (2023): 5- or 7-course tasting menus. Tue–Sat evenings; book online.
- 12 **Le GV** — One Michelin star on the 11th-floor roof of the 1926 Le Soleil hotel, in an Orient Express–style room. Dinner only, closed Sunday.
- 13 **Chophouse** — Grill at the tip of Tigné Point whose terrace (heated in winter) looks straight across at Valletta's bastions. Daily 19:00–22:30.
- 14 **Bistro Boca** — Parisian-style bistro on the Ta' Xbiex yacht front: moules frites, tartare, cassoulet. Michelin-listed; phone ahead.

SHOPPING

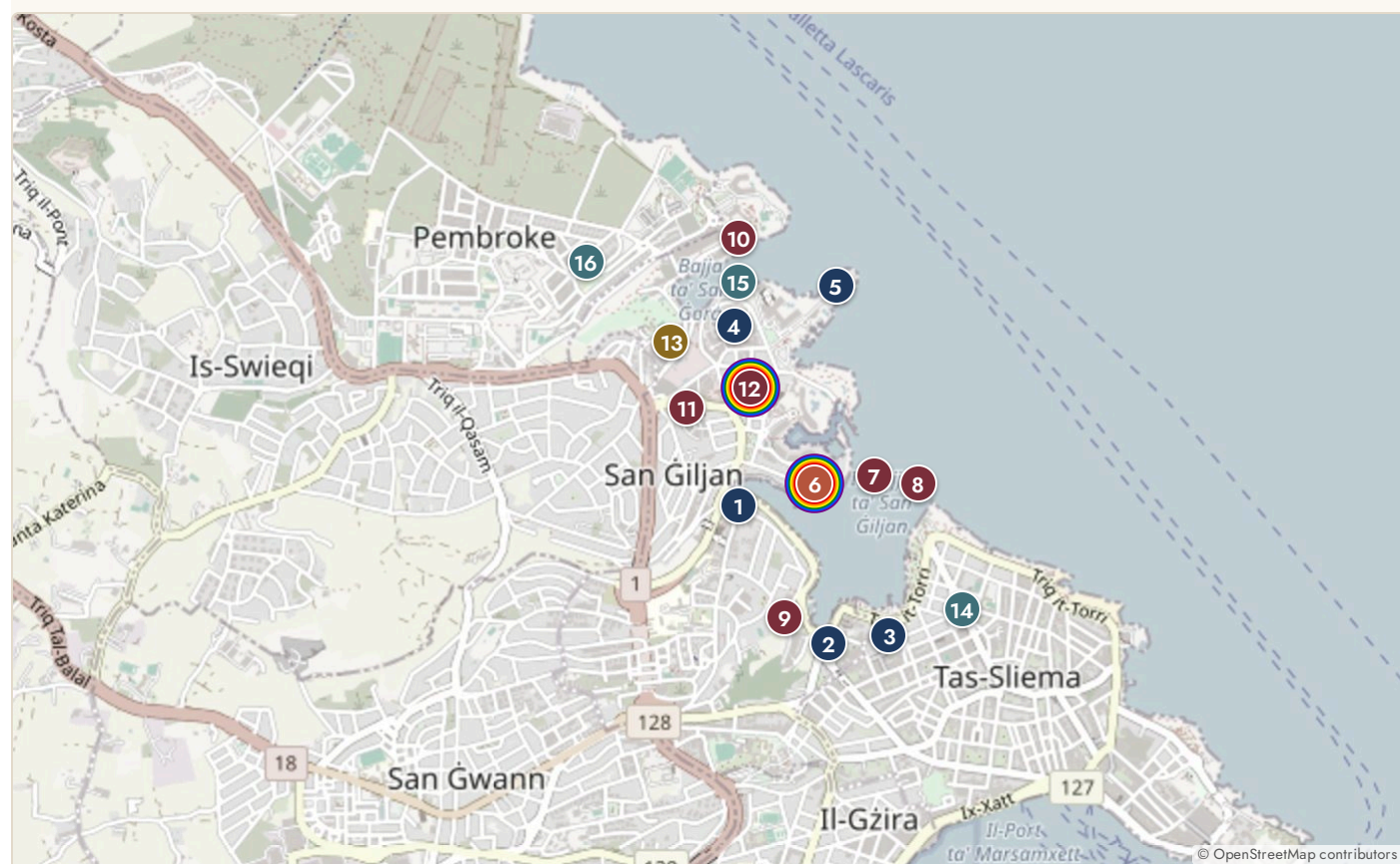
- 15 **The Point** — Tigné Point mall with Marks & Spencer and a Eurospar for self-catering. Daily 10:00–19:30.

WALKS, SWIMS & HIDDEN CORNERS

- 16 **Tower Road promenade** — About 3 km of Victorian seafront round the peninsula to Balluta — how locals walk off dinner. Independence Garden gives shade halfway.
- 17 **Exiles & the rock pools** — Ladders into deep, clear water at Exiles; the shallow Victorian “Roman Baths” at Fond Għadir for a gentle dip. The ladders come out after September, and spots close after bad water tests — check the signs.
- 18 **Sliema–Valletta ferry** — Every 30 min from the Strand to Marsamxett (€3; €5 day return). Summer timetable to 31 Oct, last boat 01:00; from 1 Nov the last boat leaves Sliema at 19:15.

4 St Julian's, Balluta & Paceville

Balluta and Spinola Bay feel like a proper seaside town — fishing boats, an Art Nouveau landmark and good restaurants, a stroll from Sliema. Uphill, Paceville is the island's club strip, loud and very young Thursday to Saturday. Stay at the Balluta or Spinola end, and expect building works.



● Sights & Museums ● Cafés & Sweets ● Restaurants & Bars ● Markets & Food Shops ● Shopping ● Walks, Swims & Hidden Corners
 ● LGBTQ+-friendly

SIGHTS & MUSEUMS

- 1 **Spinola Bay & Spinola Palace** — A working harbour of painted boats below the palace a Knight built in 1688 “for public entertainment” (exterior only). Richard England’s LOVE sign sits on the quay.
- 2 **Balluta Buildings** — Malta’s finest Art Nouveau: a 1928 apartment block with carved putti over tall arched windows, facing the neo-Gothic Carmelite church. Under renovation.
- 3 **Carmelite Church, Balluta** — The neo-Gothic parish church that, with the Balluta Buildings opposite, makes the classic Balluta photo.

- 4 **Millennium Chapel** — A calm modern chapel by Richard England in the middle of Paceville, kept by volunteers as “an oasis of peace”; 8:00–23:00 every day but Good Friday.
- 5 **Dragonara Palace** — An 1870 colonnaded villa, a casino since 1964. Walk out to Dragonara Point for the sea.



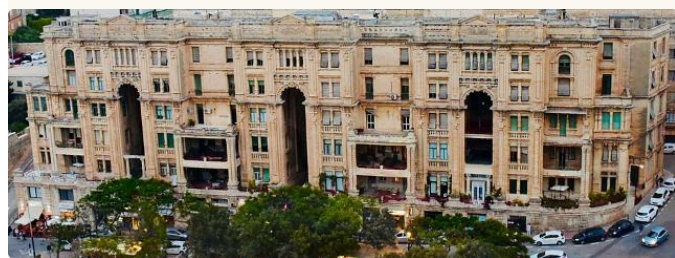
This photo was taken by Anton Zelenov. Please cr · CC BY-SA 4.0

CAFÉS & SWEETS

- 6 **Two Buoys**  — Australian brunch at 106 Spinola Rd — rösti, corn fritters, good gluten-free — and usual home of the monthly Sunday **Brunch Bunch** gay drag brunch. 9:00–16:00.

RESTAURANTS & BARS

- 7 **Gululu** — Casual Maltese on the water at 133 Spinola Bay: dips, spaghetti with rabbit, baby calamari. Daily; book 2133 3431.
- 8 **Zest** — Asian and Nikkei cooking above Spinola Bay, in the Michelin Guide four years running. Dinner daily from 18:30.
- 9 **Rosamì** — One Michelin star in a villa over Balluta Bay: surprise tasting menus of 6 or 8 courses with Maltese cheeses. Romantic. Closed Thu and Sun.
- 10 **Caviar & Bull** — Aged beef in a glass cabinet at the door; tartare, Argentine ribs, caviar. Michelin-listed and expensive. Dinner Mon–Sat, Sunday lunch.
- 11 **Le Majoliche** — Sicilian trattoria in Pender Gardens with a fresh fish display and house-made pasta. Lunch only, daily; book.
- 12 **Michelangelo Club Lounge**  — Malta's only gay club, Level 1 of the Qube building on the St Rita Steps: two floors, drag and themed nights, Wednesday men-only night, from 22:00. Loud, late and young — a one-time visit. It hosted Pride's White Party on 12 Sept 2026.



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SHOPPING

- 13 **Bay Street** — Indoor-outdoor mall at St George's Bay, 50-plus shops, daily 10:00–22:00 — for rainy days and basics.

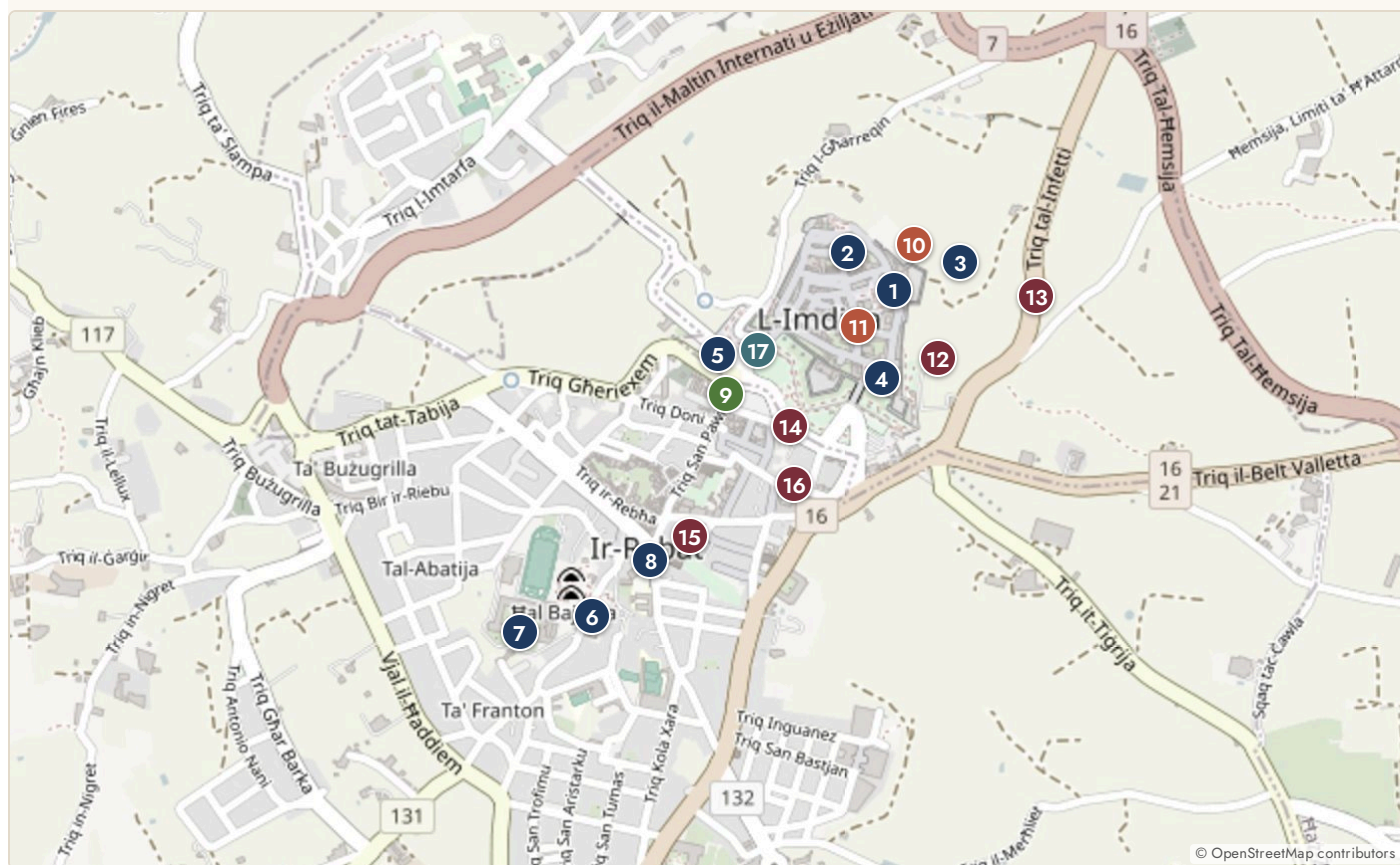
WALKS, SWIMS & HIDDEN CORNERS

- 14 **Balluta Bay** — A small re-sanded cove with a lifeguard in front of the Art Nouveau buildings; busy on summer weekends, pleasant in October.

- 15 **St George's Bay** — The area's only real sandy beach (Blue Flag): paddleboards, kayaks, sunbeds. Before 10:00 on weekends.
- 16 **Pembroke garrigue walk** — 60-plus hectares of wild karst garrigue and Aleppo pines on old army land, past the 1890s Pembroke Battery and St George's Barracks to Madliena Tower.

5 AREA Mdina & Rabat

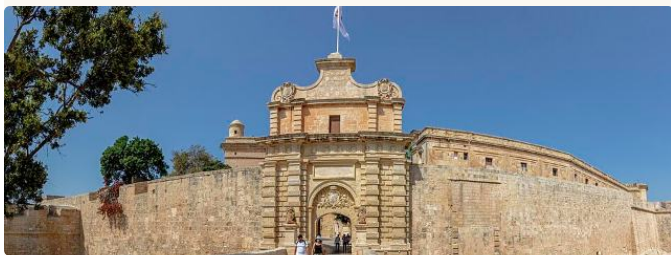
Mdina, the “silent city”, is a walled hilltop town of barely 300 people — busy with tour groups from about 10:00 to 15:00 and almost silent at dusk. Rabat, just outside the walls, is the working town: pastizzi shops, catacombs, a Sunday market and parish squares.



SIGHTS & MUSEUMS

- 1 St Paul's Cathedral & Museum** — Mattia Preti's cathedral and, across the square, a museum with Dürer woodcuts and Roman finds. €15 (60+ €10). Mon–Sat 9:30–16:30; closed Sundays and holidays.
- 2 Palazzo Falson** — A medieval palace full of Captain Gollcher's collections — arms, silver, paintings, library. Tue–Sun, last entry 16:00; €12.50 (seniors €6). Its rooftop Gustav Café is Mdina's calmest coffee.
- 3 Carmelite Priory Museum** — A working priory: see the friars' kitchen, refectory and cells, and the 1660s church. Midday break — confirm the hours.
- 4 Natural History Museum** — Birds, minerals and oddities in the Baroque Villhena Palace just inside the Main Gate. €5 (60+ €3.50).
- 5 Domvs Romana** — A wealthy Roman townhouse found in 1881: fine mosaics (Sosos' doves) and statues of Emperor Claudius and family. Daily 9:00–17:00, €6.
- 6 St Paul's Catacombs** — Twenty-plus tomb complexes with carved “agape” tables for funeral meals; €6. Low ceilings and steep steps — flat shoes; the lights are on short timers.
- 7 St Agatha's Catacombs** — Private, short guided tours through catacombs with early-Christian frescoes, plus a small museum. Closed Sundays.

- 8 **Wignacourt Museum & St Paul's Grotto** — The grotto where tradition says St Paul lived in AD 60, a museum, Punic and Roman tombs and a 50-room WWII shelter. About €5–6, daily.



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MARKETS & FOOD SHOPS

- 9 **Crystal Palace (Is-Serkin)** — Malta's most famous pastizzeria (since about 1945), open almost round the clock. Ricotta and pea pastizzi, under €1 each, with milky tea. Cash.
- **Rabat Sunday market** — A village market near St Paul's Church on Sunday mornings — household goods, local food, *fira* sandwiches. Pair it with Crystal Palace.

CAFÉS & SWEETS

- 10 **Fontanella Tea Garden** — The bastion-top terrace with views over half the island; order the layered chocolate cake. No bookings — come mid-morning or after 16:30.
- 11 **Fior di Latte** — A little gelateria at 21 Villegaignon St, 16-plus flavours — handy between Palazzo Falson and the Carmelites.



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RESTAURANTS & BARS

- 12 **De Mondion** — One Michelin star on the roof of the Xara Palace; ask for a parapet table at sunset. Book well ahead.
- 13 **The Medina** — Michelin-listed Maltese and Mediterranean cooking in an old house at 7 Holy Cross St; share the “casual bites”. Phone bookings only: 2145 0587.

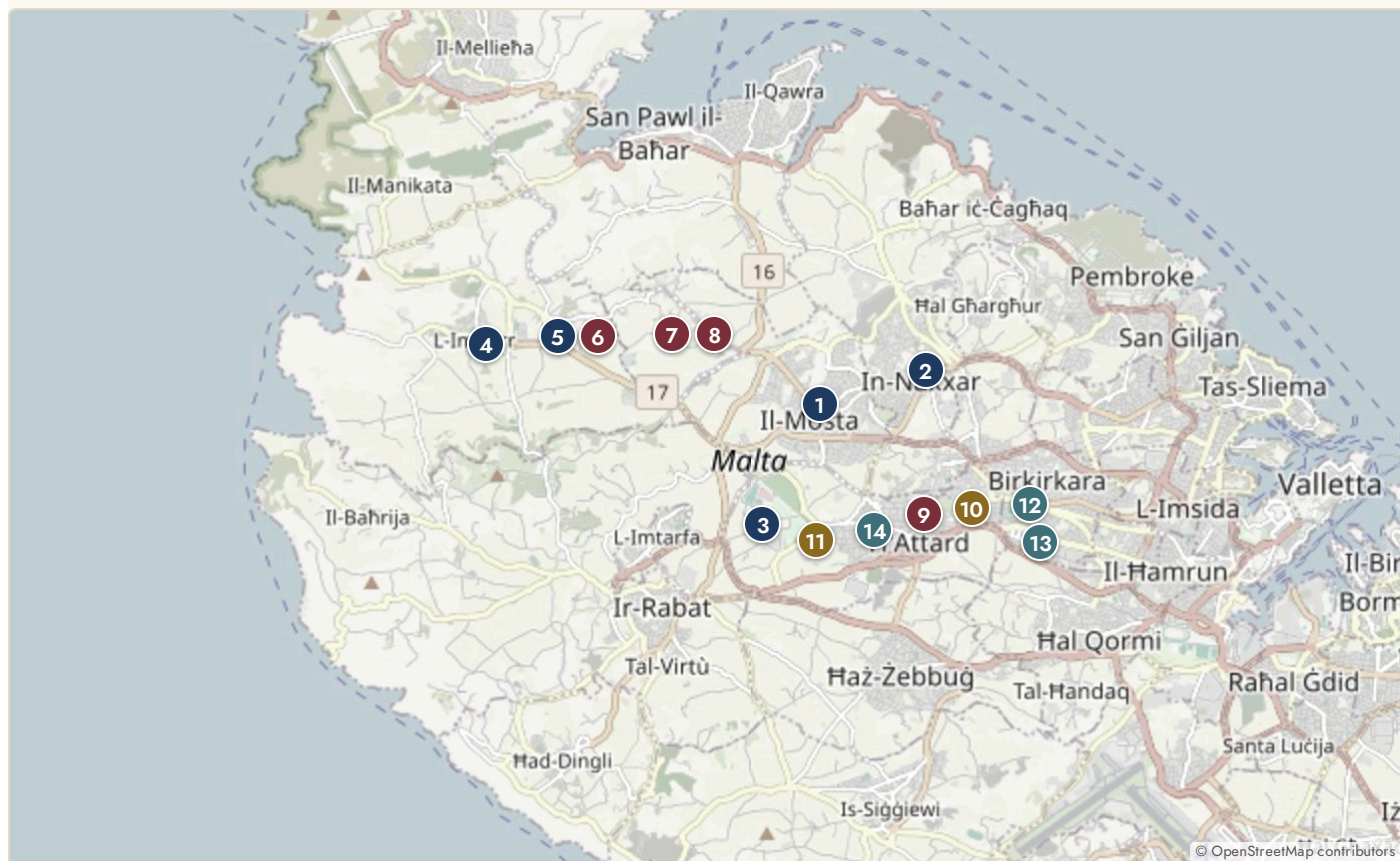
- 14 **Ta' Doni** — Casual and cheap at 73 St Paul St: Maltese platters, sandwiches, local craft beer. Daily 9:00–22:00 — lunch between the catacombs.
- 15 **Grotto Tavern** — Michelin-listed, on St Paul's Square: a garden room and “The Cave”, cut from the rock, for the tasting menu. Dinner Mon–Sat; 7945 3258.
- 16 **Root 81** — Michelin-listed Mediterranean cooking from local produce, with a terrace and views, at 22A Saqqajja Hill. Irregular hours; closed Sunday.

WALKS, SWIMS & HIDDEN CORNERS

- 17 **Mdina Ditch Garden & Greek's Gate** — The dry moat below the walls, landscaped in 2015 — the best ground-level view of the bastions. Walk round to the quieter Greek's Gate. Little shade.

6 AREA Mosta, Naxxar, Attard & Mġarr

The island's residential heart: parish-church villages, Knights-era palaces and citrus gardens linked by buses rather than tourist trails. Come for the enormous Mosta dome, a rabbit supper in a Mġarr village bar and a walk in the President's gardens with local pensioners.



● Sights & Museums ● Cafés & Sweets ● Restaurants & Bars ● Markets & Food Shops ● Shopping ● Walks, Swims & Hidden Corners
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SIGHTS & MUSEUMS

- 1 **Mosta Rotunda** — A 39.6 m dome; on 9 April 1942 a German bomb pierced it during a service and failed to explode (a replica is in the sacristy). About €5 with the dome gallery and WWII shelters. Mon–Fri 9:30–17:30, Sat to 16:30, Sun 12:00–17:00.
- 2 **Palazzo Parisio** — An 18th-century palazzo, still a private home, with a marble staircase, gilded rooms and Italianate gardens. Tue–Sun; €18 (gardens only €8). Its restaurant Luna does lunch and afternoon tea; Wednesday evenings bring “Gin & Jam” in the garden.
- 3 **Malta Aviation Museum** — Volunteer-run hangars on the old RAF Ta Kali airfield, with a Spitfire and Hurricane among the restored aircraft. Mon–Sat 9:00–17:00, Sun to 12:00; €9.
- 4 **Ta' Haġrat Temples** — Small, early UNESCO-listed temple at the edge of Mġarr (€3.50). Tickets aren't sold on site — buy online or at Il-Barri — and it opens only some days.
- 5 **Mġarr WWII shelter** — A 225 m shelter dug by hand, 12 m under the church square; enter through Il-Barri restaurant, Tue–Sun.



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MARKETS & FOOD SHOPS

- **Village markets** — Mosta on Monday mornings (produce, books, wartime bric-à-brac); Naxxar flea market Sunday 8:00–14:00; Ta' Qali farmers' market on Tuesdays and Saturday mornings for *ġbejniet*, honey and herbs.

RESTAURANTS & BARS

- 6 **Il-Barri** — Classic rabbit restaurant on Mġarr's church square: order a *fenkata* — spaghetti in rabbit sauce, then rabbit fried with garlic. Closed Monday; book weekend lunch (2157 3235).
- 7 **Mġarr United Bar** — The village football-club bar: fried rabbit, snails, octopus and *imqaret*. Dinner Tue–Sun, lunch at weekends. 2157 4630.
- 8 **Verbena** — Michelin Bib Gourmand trattoria cooking generous seasonal food from local farms. Wed–Sat dinner, Sunday lunch; no cards. 7906 2933.
- 9 **Villa Bologna** — Italian restaurant in the gardens of the 18th-century Strickland villa, next to its pottery — a pleasant stop after San Anton.



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SHOPPING

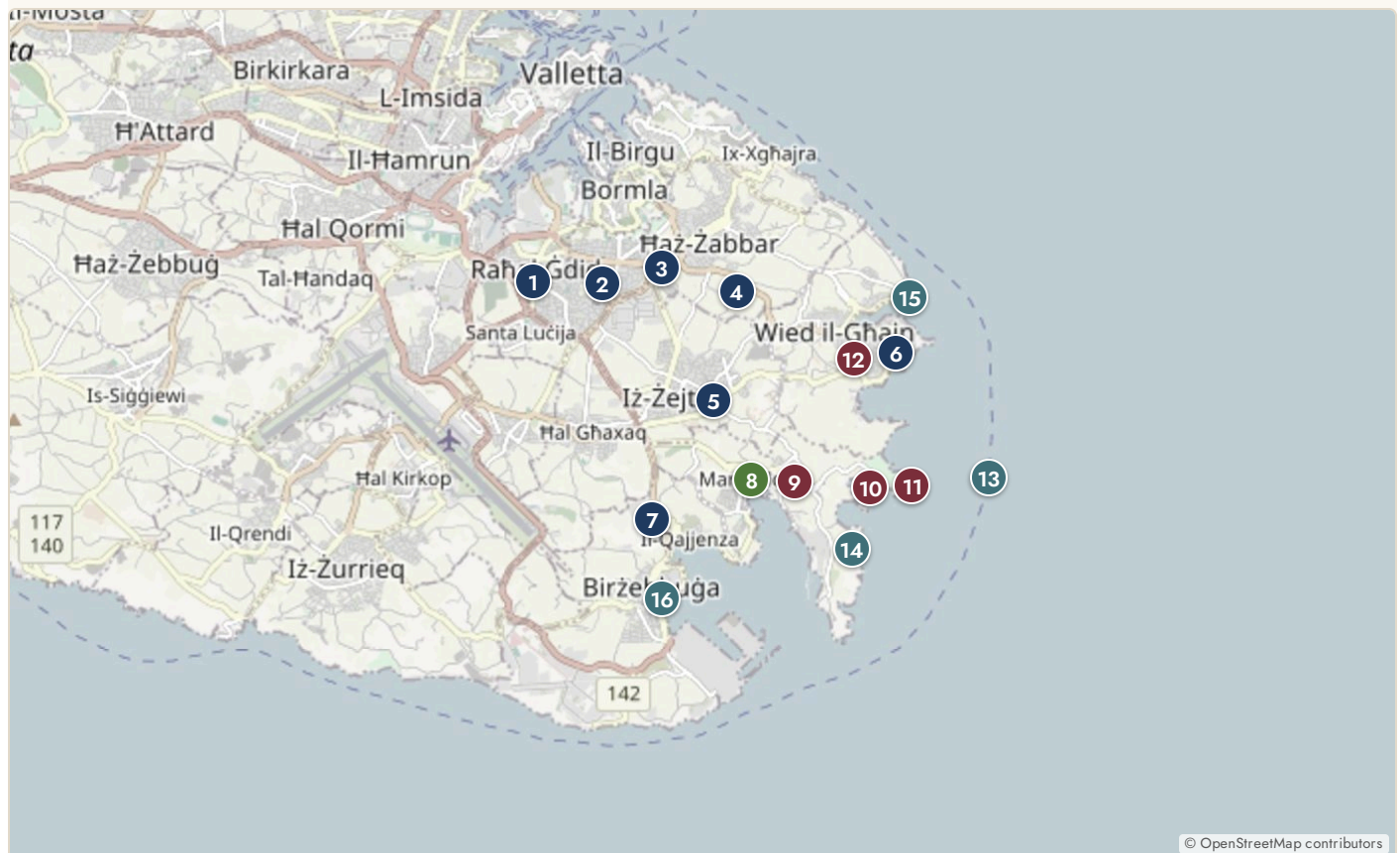
- 10 **Villa Bologna Pottery** — Hand-made tableware in local patterns, plus pottery-painting workshops in the garden.
- 11 **Ta' Qali Crafts Village** — Half-rebuilt and sadly deserted, but Mdina Glass (since 1968) and Valletta Glass still blow glass — go on a weekday morning for the demonstrations.

WALKS, SWIMS & HIDDEN CORNERS

- 12 **San Anton Gardens** — The President's gardens, public since 1882: 300-year-old trees, swans and turtles, peacocks, trees planted by visiting heads of state. Free, from 7:00. Buses 52/53.
- 13 **The Three Villages** — A walk through Attard, Balzan and Lija: Knights-era farmhouses, citrus gardens, Tommaso Dingli's 17th-century church, the Lija Belvedere.
- 14 **Ta' Qali National Park** — Malta's biggest park, on the old airfield under Mdina's ridge — flat lawns linking the aviation museum and the crafts village.

7 The South-East: Temples & Fishing Villages

The working south. Prehistoric sites sit among ordinary suburban streets, and further down the coast a fleet of painted *luzzu* boats still ties up at Marsaxlokk. Mornings are for underground temples and fish stalls; afternoons for swimming off flat rocks and grilled fish by the water.



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SIGHTS & MUSEUMS

- 1 **Hal Saflieni Hypogeum** — A Neolithic burial complex cut three levels into the rock, where the Sleeping Lady was found; 10 people per slot, no photos, about an hour. €35 (60+ €20) — **book about 3 months ahead**; €50 last-minute tickets the day before.
- 2 **Tarxien Temples** — Four temples with carved spirals and animal friezes and the base of a colossal statue (the originals are in Valletta's Archaeology Museum). €6, 10 min from the Hypogeum.
- 3 **Basilica of Christ the King** — The islands' largest church (1967), dominating Paola's square a few minutes from the Hypogeum.
- 4 **Addolorata Cemetery** — Malta's Victorian cemetery on a hill above Paola — a neo-Gothic chapel, grand family tombs, a quiet walk few tourists take.
- 5 **St Catherine's Old Church ("St Gregory's")** — Medieval church on the edge of Żejtun overlooking three bays; hidden passages full of skeletons were found in its roof in 1969. Walk Triq San Ġirgor from the Baroque parish church at golden hour, then 15 minutes downhill to Marsaxlokk.
- 6 **St Thomas Tower** — Malta's largest watchtower (1614), reopened in August 2025 as an interactive museum of corsairs and piracy. Check hours (2180 0992).

- 7 Għar Dalam** — The cave where the first evidence of people on Malta was found, packed with Ice Age bones of dwarf elephants and hippos. €6.50.



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MARKETS & FOOD SHOPS

- 8 Marsaxlokk Sunday fish market** — The quay turns into Malta's great fish market on Sunday mornings, with fish from the boats behind the stalls. Go early, before the coaches and parking jams.

RESTAURANTS & BARS

- 9 Tartarun** — Marsaxlokk's only Michelin-listed restaurant: the Schiavone family's simply cooked whole fish and modern seafood; 150-label wine list. Closed Mon and Thu; 9917 7258.
- 10 Roots** — Family-run, tables facing the boats at 67 Xatt is-Sajjieda: *aljotta*, braised octopus, fish from the board. 2165 3205.
- 11 Ir-Rizzu** — Long-running family fish restaurant on the quay with an open kitchen. 2165 1569.
- 12 Tal-Familja** — Maltese family cooking a block back from the Marsaskala front. Book by phone (2163 2161).



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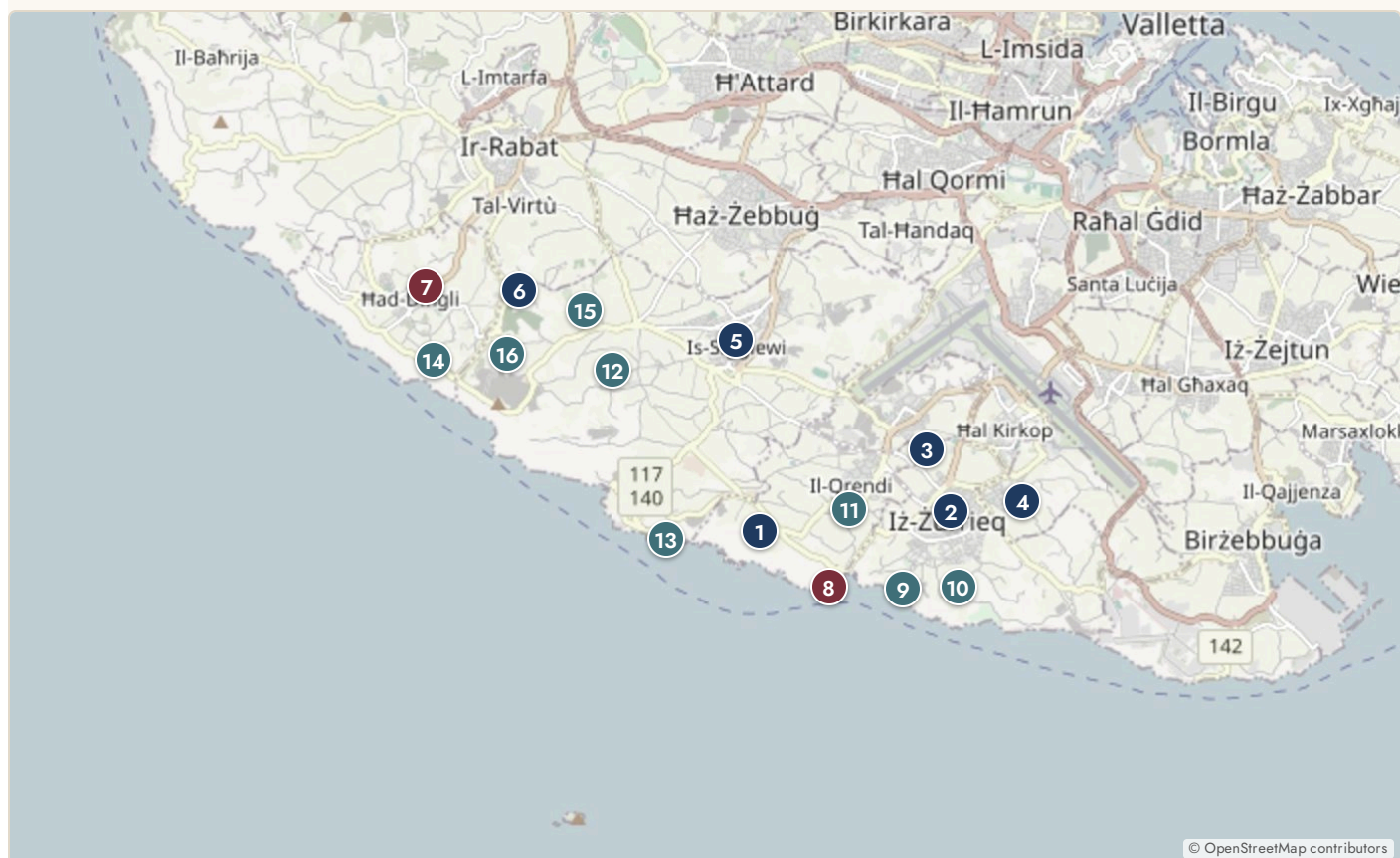
WALKS, SWIMS & HIDDEN CORNERS

- 13 Marsaxlokk waterfront** — Walk the harbour past the painted *luzzu* to Our Lady of Pompeii church. Storm Harry hit the waterfront in January 2026; some repairs continue.

- 14 St Peter's Pool** — Swim off flat limestone ledges into deep, clear water — for confident swimmers; no facilities, no shade. Best on calm weekday mornings in September or October. Walk on to Delimara Lighthouse (1855).
- 15 Żonqor Point & St Thomas Bay** — Coastal walk from Marsaskala past salt pans (lovely at sunset) and flat swimming rocks to the area's only sandy beach.
- 16 Pretty Bay** — Birżebbuġa's sandy town beach — with container cranes across the water. Pairs with Għar Dalam.

8 AREA The South-West: Cliffs, Grottoes & Temples

Malta's high, wild edge: limestone plateaus and terraced fields ending in cliffs above a deep-blue sea, with the islet of Filfla offshore. Temples in the morning, a small boat into the sea caves before the wind gets up, sunset from the top of the island at Dingli.



SIGHTS & MUSEUMS

- 1 **Haġar Qim & Mnajdra** — Two UNESCO temples, 5,000-plus years old, 500 m apart on a coastal path; equinox sunrise lights Mnajdra's inner niche. €10 (60+ €7.50) with audio guide; allow 2–3 hours.
- 2 **St Catherine, Żurrieq** — The 1630s parish church, with several Mattia Preti paintings including the *Martyrdom of St Catherine*.
- 3 **Hal Millieri Chapel** — A chapel of about 1450 standing alone where a medieval village once was. Usually shut — a quiet stop on a walk.
- 4 **Xarolla Windmill** — A restored 18th-century windmill next to a Knights-era chapel and small catacombs.

- 5 **St Nicholas, Siġġiewi** — Lorenzo Gafa's Baroque church (1676–93) with a Preti altarpiece, on the square of a town the Knights made a city.
- 6 **Verdala Palace** — A square, fortress-like 1588 summer house above Buskett, now the President's; see it from the garden paths.



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RESTAURANTS & BARS

- 7 **Diar il-Bniet** — Farm-to-table rural cooking from the family's own fields: *bigilla*, seasonal vegetables, *imqaret*. At 121 Triq il-Kbira, Dingli; 2762 0727.
- 8 **Blue Creek** — Cliff-top bar-restaurant above the boat inlet — pricey and touristy, but fine for a drink with the view after the boats.

WALKS, SWIMS & HIDDEN CORNERS

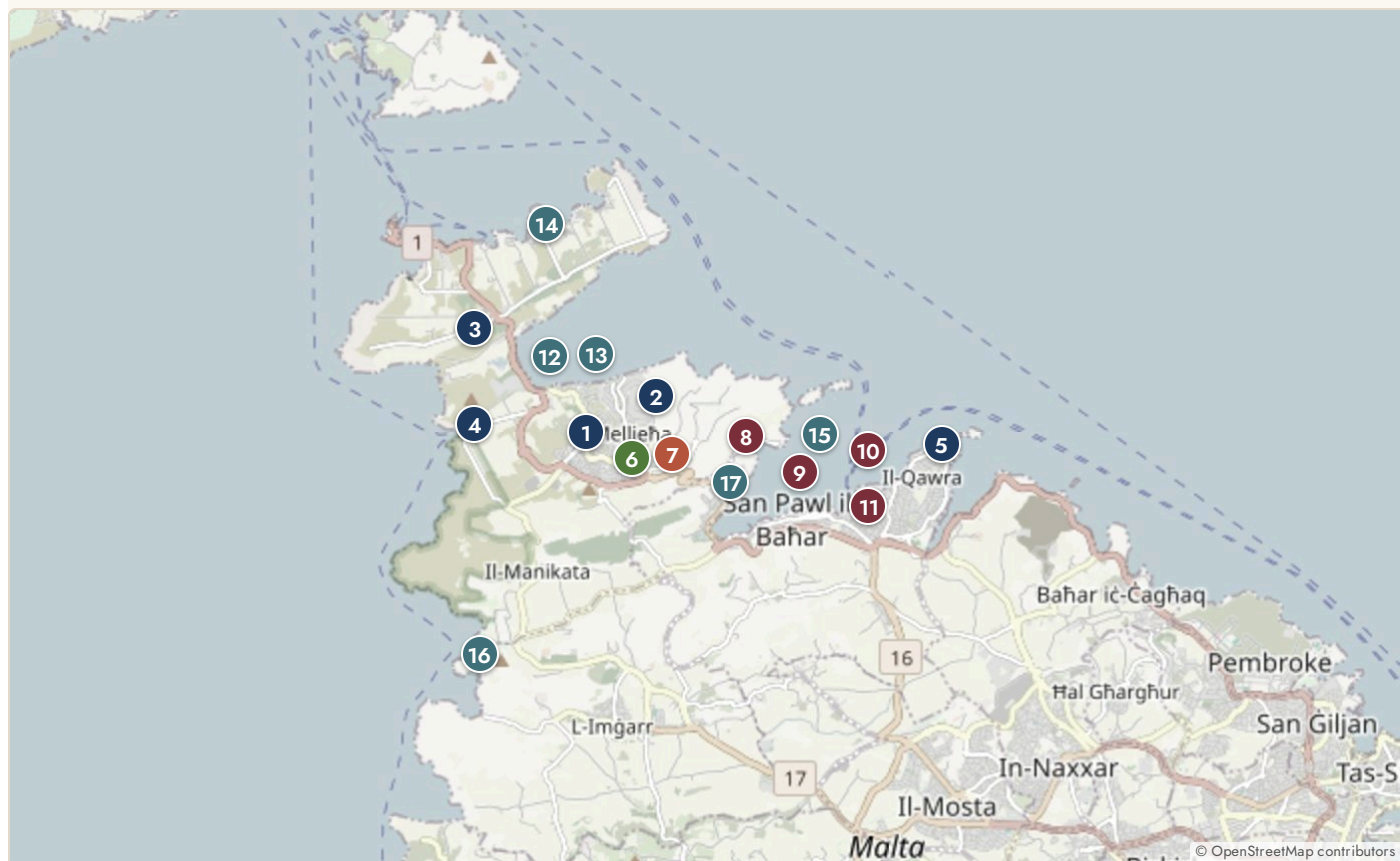
- 9 **Blue Grotto boats** — Small *luzzi* leave when full for 20–25 min in the sea caves; about €8–10, cash. Go 9:00–11:00, when the water glows cobalt. No boats in rough seas — check the wind.
- 10 **Blue Grotto viewpoint** — A free cliff-top platform on the main road looking down on the arch — the fallback when the boats aren't running.
- 11 **Il-Maqluba** — A sinkhole 50 m across that collapsed in 1343 — legend says angels threw the pieces into the sea to make Filfla — with a tiny chapel on its rim.
- 12 **Laferla Cross** — A hill-top cross above Siġġiewi reached by a path of Stations of the Cross; wide views. Candlelit pilgrimages on Maundy Thursday.
- 13 **Għar Lapsi** — A small natural swimming inlet the locals love. Storm-damaged in January 2026 — check the restaurants are open.
- 14 **Dingli Cliffs** — Nearly the highest point on Malta: a cliff-edge road, a tiny chapel of St Mary Magdalene, Filfla offshore. Come at sunset and walk back via Buskett.
- 15 **Buskett Gardens** — The Knights' hunting woods of oak, carob and Aleppo pine — the shadiest walk on the island, and a bird-migration hotspot in autumn.
- 16 **Clapham Junction cart ruts** — A bare plateau near Buskett criss-crossed by prehistoric grooves up to 60 cm deep, purpose still debated. Sturdy shoes; no shade.



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9 Mellieħa & the North

The big-sky end of Malta: Mellieħa sits on a ridge above the longest sandy beach, looking across to Comino and Gozo, with red-clay bays and garrigue walks to the west. St Paul's Bay, Buġibba and Qawra are the busy resort side, with Roman countryside right behind the flats.

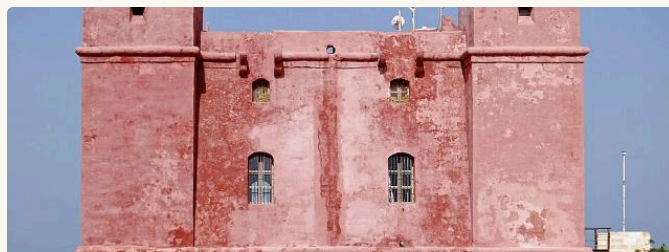


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SIGHTS & MUSEUMS

- 1 **Sanctuary of Our Lady of Mellieħa** — A 16th-century shrine at the foot of the main street, with a natural cave crypt and 17th-century paintings. Daily 8:00–18:00.
- 2 **Mellieħa Air Raid Shelter** — The biggest of Mellieħa's 46 wartime shelters: 500-plus metres through the rock, with scenes of shelter life. €2.40 — one of Malta's best-value museums.
- 3 **Red Tower (St Agatha's)** — The Knights' blood-red signal tower on Marfa Ridge; from the roof, Comino and Gozo. 10:00–16:00 in autumn; small fee (Din l-Art Helwa).

- 4 **Popeye Village** — The 1980 film set, now a family park (about €15 from 6 Nov). For adults, the free cliff-top viewpoint across Anchor Bay gives the classic photo in 15 minutes.
- 5 **Malta National Aquarium** — At Qawra Point, daily 10:00–20:00; the Mediterranean section is the most local.



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MARKETS & FOOD SHOPS

- 6 **Bixkilla & McSims** — Picnic supplies before a walk: Bixkilla's traditional bakes and made-to-order tuna sandwiches; McSims' pastizzi counter (three pastizzi and two pastries under €6).

CAFÉS & SWEETS

- 7 **TuttoBuono** — Mellieħa's pick for specialty coffee, *cannoli* and schiacciata sandwiches.



Rhododendrites · CC BY-SA 4.0

RESTAURANTS & BARS

- 8 **Commando** — Michelin Bib Gourmand, family-run since 1930 in an old stone house with a terrace; order the pappardelle with duck ragù. Dinner, closed Monday.
- 9 **Rebekah's** — Mellieħa's special-occasion dinner in a 300-year-old house with a courtyard; inventive Mediterranean cooking. Mon–Sat dinner.
- 10 **Liska** — The daily catch and octopus on a terrace facing the floodlit parish church.
- 11 **LOA** — Peruvian ceviche and cocktails on the big terrace of the Sirens water-polo club; Michelin-listed, open lunch to late — an early sunset dinner.

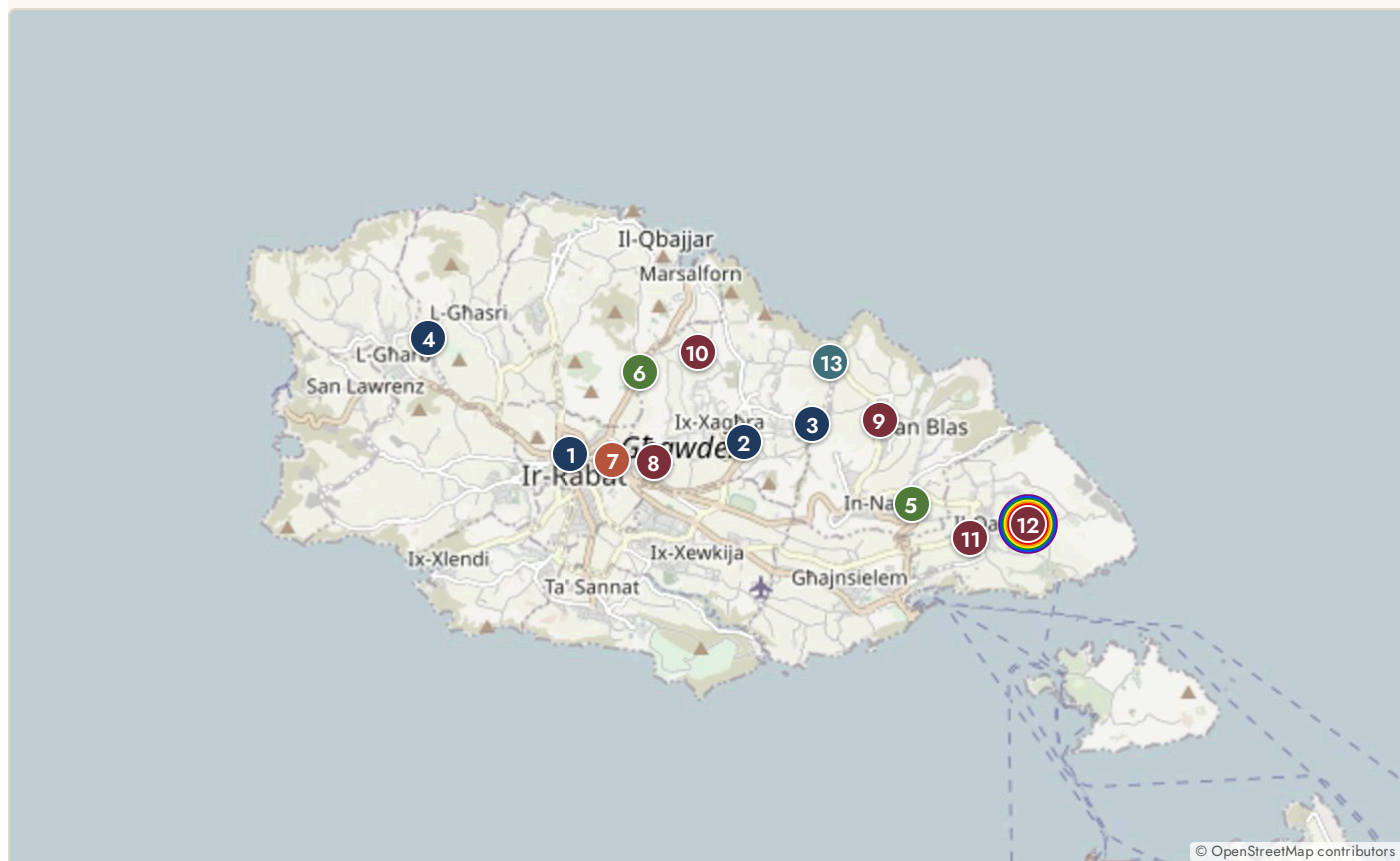
WALKS, SWIMS & HIDDEN CORNERS

- 12 **Għadira Nature Reserve** — BirdLife's wetland behind Mellieħa Bay: stilts, sandpipers, chameleons. September–May only: Mon, Wed, Fri 13:30–17:00, weekends 10:00–16:00; free.
- 13 **Mellieħa Bay** — Malta's largest sandy beach, shallow a long way out; birdwatch in the morning, swim in the afternoon.
- 14 **Marfa Ridge loop** — An 8 km loop along the ridge towards Aħrax Point, with Gozo in view. Windy — bring a layer. Bus 49 to Armier.
- 15 **Selmun Palace & Imġiebaħ** — An 18th-century fortified hunting palace (exterior only) from which paths drop to Imġiebaħ Bay and viewpoints over St Paul's Islands.

- 16 **Golden Bay to Ġnejna** — Steps down to the red sand of Għajn Tuffieħa, then 3 km along eroded clay slopes to Ġnejna Bay — slippery after rain. Stay for sunset.
- 17 **Xemxija Heritage Trail** — A 2,000-year-old Roman road past cart ruts, Punic tombs, a Roman apiary, a 1,000-year-old carob tree and Roman baths; signposted.

IO Gozo: Victoria & the Villages

Greener, slower and more rural than Malta: wood-fired bakeries, farm cheeselets and villages gathered round outsized domed churches. Victoria's hilltop Ċittadella is the centre; the ferry, bus 301 and the church bells set the day. Warm to gay couples, if quieter — there's even a Gozo Pride.

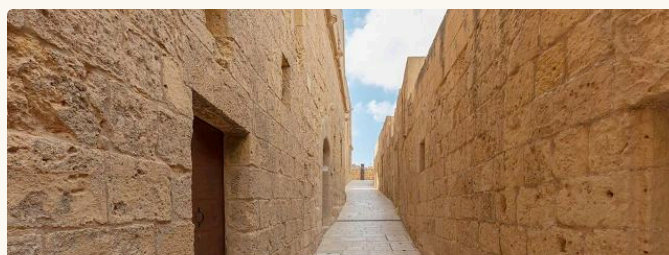


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SIGHTS & MUSEUMS

- 1 **Ċittadella** — Rebuilt 1599–1603; until 1637 all Gozitans had to sleep inside at night for fear of corsairs. Walk the ramparts free for a 360° view; Gafa's cathedral has a painted "dome" on a flat ceiling. The Archaeology Museum has been closed since April 2026 for rebuilding.
- 2 **Ġgantija Temples** — Two UNESCO temples over 5,000 years old, entered through a good visitor centre. €10 (60+ €8), including Ta' Kola Windmill; Multisite Pass.
- 3 **Ta' Kola Windmill** — A 1720s mill with its millstones, workshop and the miller's family rooms — a short walk from Ġgantija.

- 4 **Ta' Pinu & Ġhammar Hill** — Gozo's national shrine, its corridors full of ex-votos — crutches, letters, even motorbike helmets. Across the road, marble Stations of the Cross climb Ġhammar Hill to a wide view. Bus 308.



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MARKETS & FOOD SHOPS

- 5 **Nadur ftira bakeries** — Maxokk and Mekren bake Gozitan *ftira* — a pizza-like bread with potato, anchovy and olives — in wood-fired ovens. Takeaway; locals argue which is better, so try both.
- 6 **Ta' Mena Estate** — A farm estate making its own wine, oil and preserves, with tastings — the place to buy Gozitan products.

CAFÉS & SWEETS

- 7 **It-Tokk & Café Jubilee** — Victoria's main square, for pastizzi and people-watching; Café Jubilee is the classic table.



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RESTAURANTS & BARS

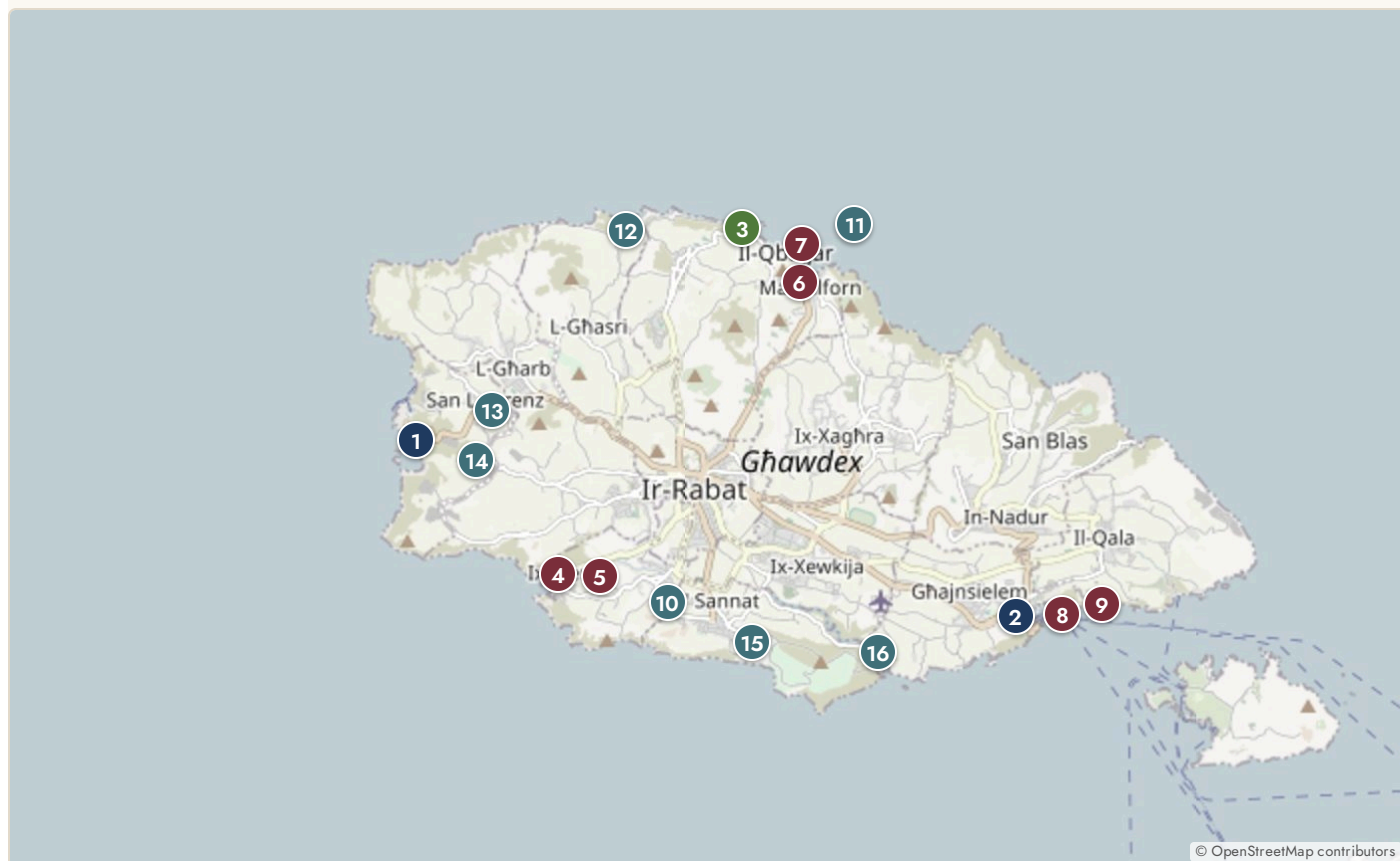
- 8 **It-Tokk Restaurant** — Gozitan home cooking above the square: rabbit stew, ravioli, *bragioli*.
- 9 **Al Sale** — Michelin-listed, on Xagħra's square, run by a chef from Toronto: prawn and scallop ravioli, veal with salsa verde. Closed Thursday.
- 10 **Ta' Frenċ** — Gozo's long-standing fine-dining address, in a farmhouse on the Marsalforn road; Michelin-listed.
- 11 **Osteria Scottadito** — Michelin-listed Italian osteria known for its homemade desserts.
- 12 **Que Bar**  — Wine and cocktail bar on Qala's square that hosted Gozo's first queer meet-up in 2025 and still holds inclusive community events.

WALKS, SWIMS & HIDDEN CORNERS

- 13 **Ramla Bay** — Gozo's best beach: red sand and protected dunes, a few kiosks, a walk down from Xagħra or Nadur.

II Gozo's Coast

Gozo's coast is mostly cliff, cut by salt pans, gorges reached by rock steps, and fishing coves where dinner is whatever came in that morning. Autumn and spring are the walking seasons, and the sea stays swimmable well into October.



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SIGHTS & MUSEUMS

- 1 Dwejra Tower** — Built in 1652 to guard Fungus Rock; usually open when the flag flies on the roof. Some of the best sea views on the island.
- 2 Lourdes Chapel** — The chapel on the slope above Mġarr harbour — the first landmark as the ferry comes in.



G.Mannaerts · CC BY-SA 4.0

MARKETS & FOOD SHOPS

- 3 Xwejni salt stalls** — Families like the Cinis (since the 1860s) sell sea salt by the road — the best souvenir to take home. Harvest ends in September.

RESTAURANTS & BARS

- 4 Ta' Karolina** — Fish and shellfish at the water's edge in Xlendi; book a front table for sunset.
- 5 The Boathouse** — Xlendi's other over-the-water fish restaurant.
- 6 Il-Kartell** — Seafront seafood in Marsalforn: fish, steaks, seafood risotto.

- 7 **Qbajjar Restaurant** — Seafood and fresh pasta — a well-placed lunch on the salt-pan walk.
- 8 **Tmun** — Michelin-listed fish restaurant at Mġarr harbour built on the day's catch — a good last meal before the ferry. Closed Tuesday.
- 9 **Level Nine** — Michelin-listed contemporary cooking on the top floor of The Grand, above the harbour.



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WALKS, SWIMS & HIDDEN CORNERS

- 10 **Xlendi Bay & Tower** — A cliff-ringed cove with Gozo's oldest free-standing watchtower (1650); cliff paths and steps to Caroline's Cave.
- 11 **Xwejni salt pans** — About 3 km of 350-year-old rock-cut pans, a chequerboard along the coast west of Marsalforn. Don't walk on the pans.
- 12 **Wied il-Għasri** — A deep gorge with rock-cut steps down to a pebble cove; spectacular in rough seas. Links to Xwejni on a 3 km walk. No handrail — slippery when wet.
- 13 **Dwejra Inland Sea** — A cliff-ringed lagoon joined to the open sea by a 100 m tunnel; fishermen run short boat trips out through it. The Azure Window arch nearby collapsed in 2017.
- 14 **Fungus Rock & the Blue Hole** — The Knights smoothed this rock's sides to protect its prized medicinal "fungus". The Blue Hole beside it is one of the Mediterranean's classic dives.
- 15 **Ta' Ċenċ cliffs** — An easy 4 km clifftop walk from Sannat above some of Gozo's highest cliffs (private land — walk respectfully). Bus 305.
- 16 **Mġarr ix-Xini** — A narrow fjord of an inlet with a 1661 watchtower and fishing boats — a quiet swim.

Valletta, City Gate to Fort St Elmo

Grand Master Jean de Valette founded his city the year after the Great Siege of 1566, on a grid built for defence and for the sea breeze. This walk runs its length, gently downhill; start by 9:00 to beat the cruise crowds, or do it on a Sunday afternoon when the city is locals only.

1 Start: City Gate & Parliament

Renzo Piano's City Gate and stone Parliament, and the roofless Royal Opera House, bombed in 1942 and now an open-air theatre.

2 Upper Barrakka Gardens

Left along South Street to the arcades over the Grand Harbour; the Saluting Battery fires at noon. Next door, the Auberge de Castille, the Prime Minister's office.

3 St John's Co-Cathedral

Down Merchants Street to the Knights' church and Caravaggio's *Beheading of St John* (closed Sundays).

4 Republic Street & Caffè Cordina

The main street; the National Library behind Queen Victoria's statue, and coffee and a *qassata* at the Cordina bar.

5 Grand Master's Palace

State rooms and the Armoury on St George's Square; detour to Old Theatre Street for the Manoel Theatre (1731) and St Paul's Shipwreck Church.

6 Lower Barrakka & the Siege Bell

Views over the harbour mouth — the Lower Barrakka is closed for renovation in 2026, so look in from the Siege Bell memorial next to it.

7 Finish: Fort St Elmo

The star fort of 1565, the George Cross and *Faith*. Walk back up Republic Street, or take the Barrakka lift down to the Three Cities ferry at sunset.



St John's Co-Cathedral — Simon Burchell · CC BY-SA 4.0



Grand Master's Palace — Jaakko.kulta · CC BY 4.0



Fort St Elmo — Txlxt Txlxt · CC BY-SA 4.0

Across the Grand Harbour

The best half-day in Malta costs about €8: down in the lift, across by ferry, round the Three Cities on foot and back in a hand-rowed boat as the lights come on.

1 Start: Barrakka lift

From the Upper Barrakka, the lift drops 58 m to the waterfront; walk to the Lascaris ferry landing.

2 Ferry to Cospicua

Ten minutes across the harbour, about every 30 minutes (buy a return — it includes the lift back up).

3 Senglea & the Gardjola

Along the Senglea waterfront to the Gardjola sentry box and its garden at the point, facing Valletta.

4 Bormla's Dock No. 1

Back past the dry docks to the little Karl Marx bridge and coffee at DATE Art Café.

5 Birgu: the Collachio

Up to Victory Square and into the Knights' lanes; the Inquisitor's Palace is on the main street.

6 Fort St Angelo

Along the marina to the fort for the late light, then a drink or supper at Terrone under its walls.

7 Finish: a dghajsa home

From the Birgu waterfront, a boatman rows or motors you back to Valletta (about €2–3 each, cash).



Senglea's waterfront — Plamen Agov (Пламен Агов) · CC BY-SA 3.0



A dghajsa on the Grand Harbour — MrPanyGoff · CC BY-SA 3.0

What to eat & drink

Maltese food is Sicilian at the core, with Arab roots, British habits and serious rabbit. Most of it is cheap and eaten standing up.

DISH	WHAT IT IS	WHERE & WHEN
<i>Pastizzi</i>	Flaky diamond pastries with ricotta or mushy peas	Any pastizzeria, all day; Crystal Palace, Rabat
<i>Qasatat</i>	Round shortcrust pies — ricotta, peas or spinach	Same shops
<i>Hobż biz-żejt</i>	Sourdough rubbed with tomato paste, oil, tuna, capers, olives	Beach and lunch snack everywhere
<i>Ftira</i>	Ring-shaped bread; in Gozo a pizza-like bake with potato and anchovy	Nadur bakeries; sandwiches everywhere
<i>Stuffat tal-fenek</i>	Rabbit slow-cooked in wine and garlic; a <i>fenkata</i> is a rabbit feast	Mġarr's village bars; book Sunday lunch
<i>Torta tal-lampuki</i>	Dorado pie with spinach, olives and raisins	Late August–December only
<i>Aljotta</i>	Garlicky fish soup with rice and mint	Marsaxlokk; Leggin
<i>Bigilla</i>	Broad-bean and garlic dip	Starter, with galletti crackers
<i>Ġbejniet</i>	Small sheep's cheeses: fresh, dried or peppered	Gozo especially; on every platter
<i>Imqaret & kannoli</i>	Fried date pastries; ricotta-filled tubes	Festa stalls, pastry shops
Kinnie & Cisk	Bitter-orange soft drink; the local lager	Everywhere
Maltese wine	Native grapes Ġellewża (red) and Ġirgentina (white)	Wine bars; Marsovin, Meridiana, Ta' Mena



Pastizzi — Kritzolina · CC BY-SA 4.0

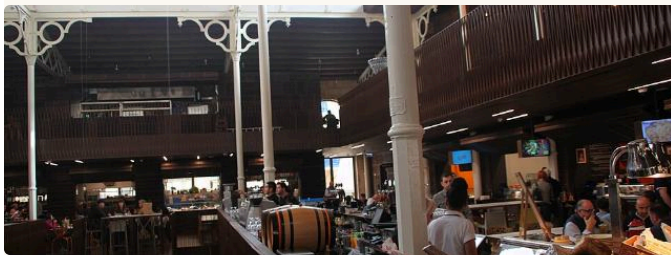


Hot from the oven — Monica Farrugia · CC BY 3.0

Markets by day

For a month-long stay, the weekly markets are the rhythm of the week — go early, before the heat and the coaches.

DAY	MARKET	WHAT FOR
Daily	Is-Suq tal-Belt, Valletta	Groceries downstairs, food court upstairs
Monday	Mosta, by the Rotunda (6:00–12:00)	Produce, old books, bric-à-brac
Tuesday	Birgu (to about 11:30); Ta' Qali farmers' market	Produce and fish; cheeses, honey
Saturday	Ta' Qali farmers' market (morning)	Farm produce, <i>ġbejniet</i>
Sunday	Marsaxlokk fish market	The week's catch
Sunday	Birgu flea market (6:00–12:00)	Records, antiques, WWII memorabilia
Sunday	Naxxar (8:00–14:00); Rabat (morning)	Flea market; village market
Year-round	Xwejni salt stalls, Gozo	Sea salt from the pans (harvest ends in Sept)



Is-Suq tal-Belt, Valletta — Benreis · CC BY-SA 4.0

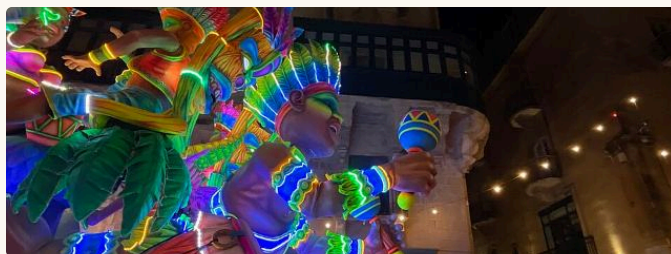
Festas & events by month

Each parish fêtes its patron saint once a year — street decorations, brass bands, fireworks and a procession — mostly June to September. Around them, a calendar of arts festivals fills the rest of the year.

MONTH	WHAT'S ON
January	Valletta Baroque Festival (7–24 Jan 2027); Bethlehem f'Ghajnsielem living nativity, Gozo
February	St Paul's Shipwreck (10 Feb); Carnival in Valletta and wild, unofficial Nadur (5–9 Feb 2027)
March–April	Holy Week processions (Good Friday 26 Mar 2027); International Fireworks Festival in April
May–June	Festgħana folk festival; Malta International Arts Festival; Imnarja at Buskett (28–29 June)
July	Malta Jazz Festival on the Valletta waterfront; festa season in full swing
August	St Lawrence, Birgu (10 Aug); Santa Marija (15 Aug), the biggest festa day
September	Victory Day regatta in the Grand Harbour (8 Sept); Malta Pride (early–mid Sept); Independence Day (21 Sept)
October	Notte Bianca (3 Oct 2026); Rolex Middle Sea Race (17 Oct); BirguFest candlelight (usually October — confirm); Three Palaces Festival (28 Oct–1 Nov)
November	Quiet; In Guardia parades at Fort St Elmo
December	Immaculate Conception, Cospicua (8 Dec); Republic Day (13 Dec); Christmas cribs; Bethlehem f'Ghajnsielem



A village festa — Melvin Degiorgio · CC BY-SA 4.0



Carnival in Valletta — Nenoc72 · CC BY-SA 4.0

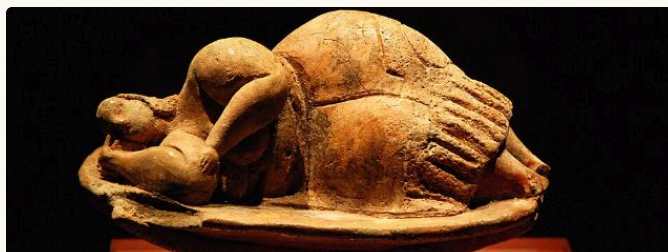
The temples & 7,000 years of history

Malta's megalithic temples (about 3600–2500 BC) are among the oldest free-standing buildings on earth. After them came Phoenicians, Romans, St Paul's shipwreck (AD 60), the Arabs (whose language became Maltese), Normans, the Knights of St John (1530–1798) and their Great Siege of 1565, Napoleon, the British, the WWII siege and the George Cross (1942), independence (1964) and the EU (2004).

SITE	WHERE	HIGHLIGHT	TICKETS
Ġgantija	Xagħra, Gozo	The oldest pair of temples, about 3600 BC	Multisite Pass
Haġar Qim	Qrendi	Hilltop temple of huge megaliths, sea view	Shared ticket with Mnajdra
Mnajdra	Qrendi	Solstice and equinox sunrise alignment	Same ticket
Tarxien	Tarxien	Spirals, animal friezes, colossal statue base	Multisite Pass
Ta' Haġrat & Skorba	Mġarr, Żebbiegħ	Small, early temples	Limited days, pre-book
Hal Saffieni Hypogeum	Paola	Underground tombs, ochre paintings, "Oracle Room"	Separate; book 3 months ahead
National Museum of Archaeology	Valletta	The Sleeping Lady and the "Venus" figurines	Multisite Pass



Ġgantija, Gozo — Diego Delso · CC BY-SA 4.0



The Sleeping Lady — Photographer: Jan van der Crabben (jvdc) · CC BY-SA 3.0

Choosing your home base

Valletta

Sights at your door, quiet and candle-lit after about 22:00, the bus hub and both harbour ferries, and the heart of the gay scene. Against it: steep stepped streets, old buildings without lifts, the highest rents and day-time cruise crowds. Ask for a lift and air-conditioning, and avoid rooms above bars.

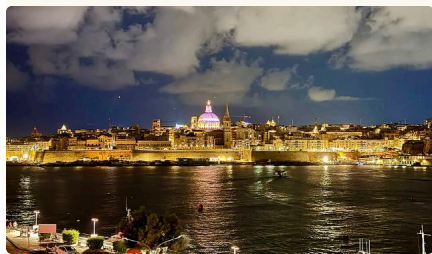
Sliema & Gżira

Flat seafront promenade and rock swims, supermarkets and services, the 10-minute ferry to Valletta, TD3 to the airport and the widest choice of long-stay flats. Against it: traffic, construction noise (check what's being built next door) and less old-Malta character.

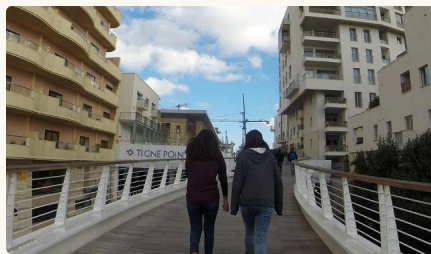
The Three Cities

Birgu or Senglea: quiet historic lanes, the marina, cheaper than Valletta for the same character, the ferry across every 30 minutes. Against it: fewer shops and restaurants, hills, and from November the last ferry is around 19:15, so evenings in Valletta end with a bus or a Bolt.

All three are within 15 minutes of each other by boat, and every other chapter is a bus ride away. **The alternative:** Gozo (Victoria or a village farmhouse) is rural, slow and cheapest, but each mainland day adds 1.5–2 hours each way and fast ferries stop in a *griegale* — better as a 2–3 night stay (see Day trips).



Valletta from Sliema — Chris Olszewski · CC BY-SA 4.0



Sliema's seafront — Alan C. Bonnici · CC BY-SA 3.0

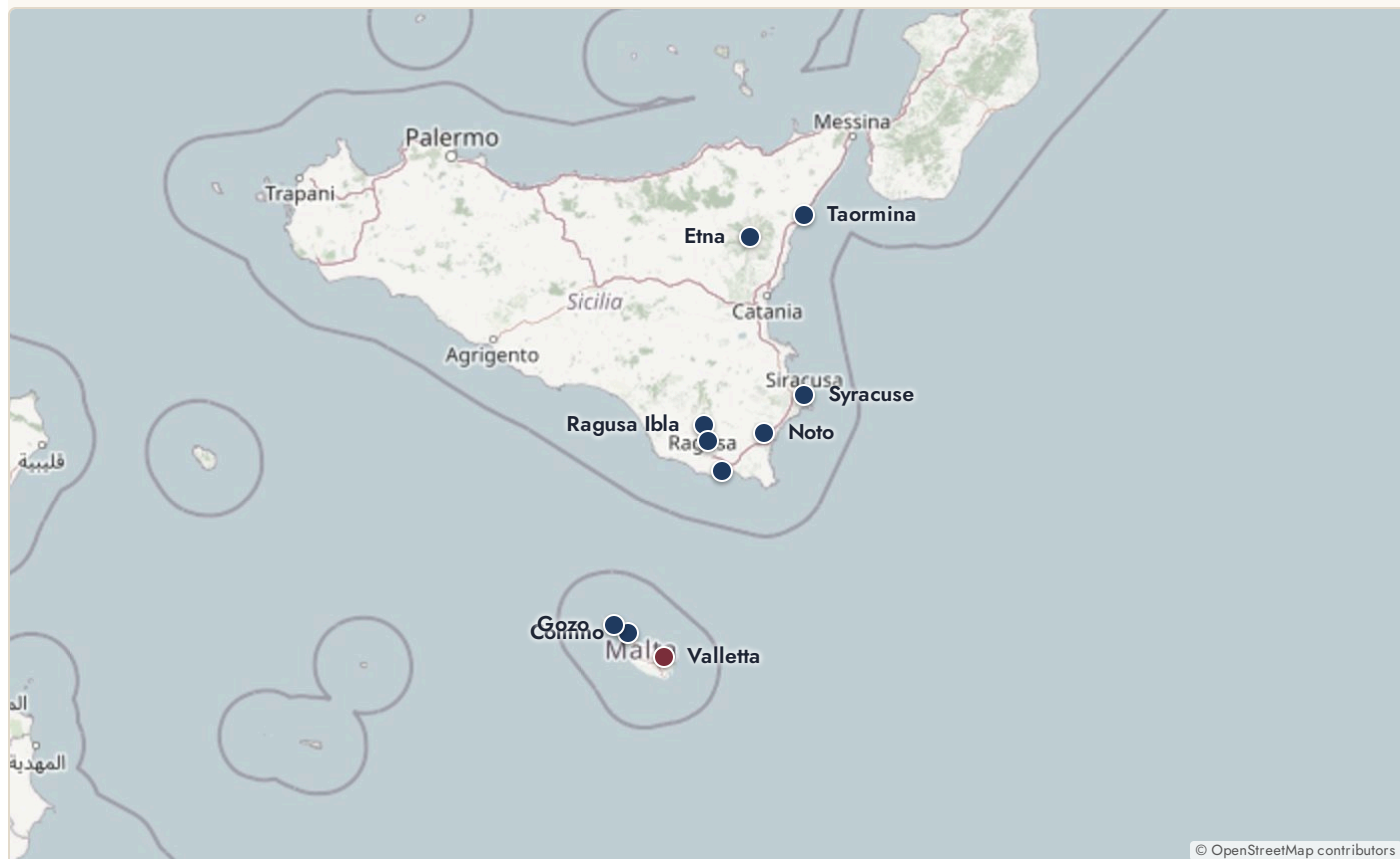


Senglea — Diego Delso · CC BY-SA 4.0

Day trips and overnight extensions — Comino, Gozo and Sicily — have their own chapters, starting on the next page.

Day trips & extensions

A 30-day stay leaves time for a slow Gozo stay, a morning on Comino and at least one trip to Sicily, 1 h 45 away by catamaran from the Grand Harbour.



DESTINATION	GETTING THERE	BEST AS
Comino & the Blue Lagoon	Comino Ferries from Ċirkewwa or Marfa, 20 min, €15 return; free lagoon pass	Morning or day trip
Slow Gozo	Ferry from Ċirkewwa 25 min, or fast ferry from Valletta 45 min	2–3 nights
Syracuse & Ortigia	Virtu catamaran to Pozzallo 1 h 45, then 1 h by road	Long day, better 1 night
Val di Noto baroque towns	Virtu to Pozzallo, then 15–40 km; Wednesday tours Oct–Apr	2–3 nights
Etna & Taormina	Virtu tour (Thursdays from 1 Oct), or on your own via Catania	1–2 nights; day tour possible

Comino & the Blue Lagoon



Frank Vincentz · CC BY-SA 3.0



Wusel007 · CC BY-SA 3.0

GETTING THERE Comino Ferries sail from Ċirkewwa (buses 41, 42, 221, 222) and Marfa about every 30 minutes, 8:30 to about 17:00; €15 return. Since 2025 landing at the Blue Lagoon needs a **free timed pass** from blcomino.com (slots 8:00–13:00, 13:30–17:30, 18:00–22:00); the rest of the island doesn't. Boats stop in bad weather and thin out in winter; the public ferry usually winds down in mid-October.

A LITTLE HISTORY

A 3.5 km² island between Malta and Gozo, home to two people in 2020. The Knights kept it as a hunting ground; Grand Master Wignacourt built St Mary's Tower in 1618 against corsairs, and knights guilty of minor offences were sometimes posted there as punishment. Today it's a bird sanctuary, and a film set for *Troy* and *The Count of Monte Cristo*.

THINGS TO DO

The lagoon early or late

Take the 8:00 slot and the first boat for turquoise water over white sand before the day-boats; swim across to Cominotto.

Santa Marija Bay

The quieter sandy bay on the north coast, via the tiny Holy Family chapel.

St Mary's Tower

A 25-minute walk inland on dirt tracks to the 1618 tower, with Gozo and Malta on either side.

Loop the island

Two to three hours on foot over thyme-scented garrigue past the 1716 battery and the old isolation hospital. No shade — bring water.

Tips: October and spring are best: warm water, quiet paths. Hats, water and sturdy sandals — there are only a few kiosks by the lagoon.

Slow Gozo



Paul Stephenson from London · CC BY 2.0

GETTING THERE Gozo Channel ferries from Ċirkewwa every 30–45 minutes, day and night (25 min; pay the €4.65 return at Mgarr on the way back), or the fast ferry from Valletta, Sliema or Bugibba. Buses fan out from the Victoria terminus.

A LITTLE HISTORY

Settled in the Neolithic, Gozo has the oldest temples of all at Ġgantija. The Ċittadella was the island's refuge from corsairs — in 1551 an Ottoman raid carried off most of the population. Gozo has stayed more rural and traditional than Malta: stone farmhouses, terraced fields, salt pans, village festas.

THINGS TO DO

Stay in a farmhouse

A converted stone farmhouse with a pool in Għarb, Xagħra or Għasri; dinner on the village square is part of the point.

Victoria early

The Ċittadella ramparts before the day-trippers, then coffee on It-Tokk.

Ta' Ċenċ at sunset

The high southern cliffs above Sannat, with cart ruts and dolmen remains on the plateau.

The north coast

Xwejni salt pans to Wied il-Għasri on foot; another day, Ġgantija and the red sand of Ramla.

Tips: Go midweek, when Maltese weekenders aren't filling the farmhouses. The Duke Boutique Hotel in Victoria is recommended as LGBTQ+-friendly; LGBTI+ Gozo keeps a map of welcoming places.

Syracuse & Ortigia



Alfonso Messina Siracusa · CC BY-SA 4.0



Yiannis Vacondios · CC BY-SA 4.0

GETTING THERE Virtu Ferries' catamaran from its Marsa terminal in the Grand Harbour (bus 130 to Hatab) to Pozzallo, 1 h 45, then about an hour by road. Day-return offers ran €63.60–101.60 in 2026; Virtu's guided Syracuse tour (€139) runs only May–September. **Bring your passport** — the ferry checks ID even inside Schengen.

A LITTLE HISTORY

Corinthians founded Syracuse on the island of Ortigia in 734 BC; it grew to rival Athens, which it defeated in 413 BC. Archimedes was born here and died in the Roman siege of 212 BC. The cathedral is built into a 5th-century-BC temple of Athena, whose Doric columns still stand in its walls.

THINGS TO DO

Piazza Duomo

The temple columns inside the cathedral, and one of Sicily's loveliest Baroque squares.

Neapolis

The rock-cut Greek Theatre and the echoing Ear of Dionysius, 10 minutes by taxi.

Arethusa & the sea walls

The papyrus spring of the nymph Arethusa, then the walls to Castello Maniace.

Ortigia market

Morning stalls by the Temple of Apollo — swordfish, capers, cheese — and lunch in the old Giudecca.

Tips: A day trip gives only 6–7 hours ashore; a night in Ortigia lets you see the Duomo floodlit and take a relaxed boat back.

Noto, Modica & Ragusa Ibla



Berthold Werner · CC BY-SA 4.0



Wikipediano 1348. Own work · CC BY-SA 4.0

GETTING THERE Catamaran to Pozzallo (see Syracuse), then 15 km to Modica, 30 to Ragusa and 30–40 to Noto; regional trains are infrequent, so book transfers or hire a car. Virtu's winter tour of Ragusa Ibla, Modica and Scicli runs on Wednesdays, October 2026–April 2027 (€139).

A LITTLE HISTORY

The 1693 earthquake flattened south-east Sicily, and the towns were rebuilt in theatrical late Baroque — Noto on a new site, Ragusa as a new upper town beside the old Ibla. UNESCO lists eight “Late Baroque Towns of the Val di Noto”.

THINGS TO DO

Noto

The steps of San Nicolò cathedral (rebuilt after its dome fell in 1996) and the carved monsters under Palazzo Nicolaci's balconies.

Ragusa Ibla

Down the long staircase to Gagliardi's Duomo di San Giorgio and the Giardino Ibleo.

Modica chocolate

Grainy, cold-worked chocolate at Antica Dolceria Bonajuto (1880), then the stairs to San Giorgio.

Scicli

Via Mormino Penna, lined with Baroque churches; the town hall is Montalbano's police station.

Tips: Base in Modica or Ragusa Ibla for two nights and add Noto on the way back. Good shoes for the stairs; the stone glows gold in the evenings the day tour misses.

Etna & Taormina



Radek Kucharski from Warsaw, Poland · CC BY 2.0



Walter Isack (isiwal) · CC BY-SA 3.0 at

GETTING THERE Virtu's guided Etna & Taormina day (€159) runs on Thursdays from 1 October 2026 to 10 January 2027: Malta 6:30 → back 23:15, about 7 of its 17 hours spent travelling. Better: catamaran to Pozzallo, then on via Catania for a night or two in Taormina.

A LITTLE HISTORY

Etna, over 3,300 m, is Europe's highest active volcano; in 1669 its lava reached Catania's walls. Greeks founded Taormina in the 4th century BC; its theatre, rebuilt by the Romans, frames the smoking volcano across the bay and drew Grand Tour travellers from the 1800s.

THINGS TO DO

Silvestri Craters

Walk the rims of extinct side craters at about 2,000 m on black lava and red cinders — bring a warm layer.

Corso Umberto

Gate to gate along the main street to the belvedere of Piazza IX Aprile and a granita.

Teatro Antico

The theatre at opening time, with the Ionian Sea below and Etna behind.

Isola Bella or Castelmola

Overnight only: down to the islet on its sandbar, or up to the hill village for the view back.

Tips: The upper mountain closes or reroutes when Etna is active or the weather turns — keep the plan flexible.

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- European Coffee Trip — COFFEE & strangers
- ETIAS — launch date dropped (July 2026)

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